

TRAIN WITH **TAKU**



Hench Head Start



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Introduction

Firstly, thank you for purchasing this guide. The information from here will set you with a great foundation of actionable knowledge for building muscle and strength. I have deliberately kept the jargon to an effective minimum to make this user-friendly (though you can find a table of key terms in chapter 3, pages 16 – 18). The purpose of this book is to teach you how to coach yourself and remove some of the guesswork when planning your new weight training routine.

What's in this guide?

- The basic rules of building muscle
- FAQs section, addressing any concerns/questions you may have about building muscle in general, or the specific content in this guide.
- An introduction to training principles: Exercise selection, volume, progression schemes and more.
- A guide on how to set up your own training. There are customisable templates, suggesting how to structure different **types** of exercises (pg. 38 – 42). You can use the templates to design your own routine, selecting from the pool of **92 exercises** in the exercise library (pg. 59 – 159).
- Alternatively, if you want a “ready-made” routine, there are sample programs (pg. 44 – 58), constructed using the templates and the principles outlined in this guide.
- The templates and sample programs have 3,4 and 5-day-per-week options available.
- Exercise tutorials are included in the library. Every exercise has the corresponding form advice, as well as links to the video demonstrations from the ‘Train with Taku’ YouTube platform.

What this guide isn't

- This is not a detailed nutrition guide, although there is a brief section on nutrition for building muscle in chapter 1. The primary focus of this guide is on the training aspect.
- This is not me just chucking a list of exercises at you. You will be introduced to the principles of building muscle and will learn how to design your program.



Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

FAQ 1) Why bother with weight training? Why build muscle? Surely, it's just for vanity?

Consistently performing progressive weight training helps maintain muscle and bone mass, reducing the effects of age-related conditions such as sarcopenia and osteoporosis [1][2]. Simply put, resistance training can slow down the physical effects of ageing. So, there is much more to it than pure vanity! Additionally, resistance training **will** be beneficial if you are trying to lose fat for two reasons. Firstly, it makes your body more inclined to build/maintain muscle while in a calorie deficit. "Use it or lose it." Additionally, if you have more muscle mass, you burn more calories at rest [4], meaning you can still be in a calorie deficit while eating more calories than you would have done otherwise.

There's also the mental aspect. Weight training has been linked with reduced anxiety, improved mood, increased confidence, and improved mental sharpness [6][7][8]. We all know that great feeling after completing a workout. Furthermore, resistance training can slow down age-related cognitive decline [8]. In other words, it can slow the mental effects of ageing as well as the physical effects. Hopefully, you're sold on the idea of weight training now!

FAQ 2) I want to be toned, but I don't want to be bulky. Should I still lift weights?

Yes. A concern which is particularly common amongst newbies is the idea that weight training will cause you to resemble the "bulky" professional bodybuilders we see. Please note that I'm **not** shaming any bodybuilders who may have that aesthetic. They have their own goals, and their work ethic is extraordinary. However, they are a small minority. The "bulkiest" professional bodybuilders are most likely using performance-enhancing drugs (PEDs) and/or following an extremely advanced nutrition and training regime, **deliberately** designed for that purpose.

Building muscle is very slow if you are a natural trainee (i.e., without PEDs), for both males and females. So, the "bulky" appearance is **VERY** hard to get. Everyone should weight train!

Now, how to get toned? The "toned" appearance comes from a combination of losing fat **AND** building muscle. There is no such thing as a "toning exercise" or a "toning rep range." Many people may only perform cardio and reduce calories in the hope of appearing toned. While they may lose fat with this approach, they may still not have the "toned and defined" look that they desire, due to the lack of muscle tissue. You cannot "tighten" the muscle to make it look more defined. You can only increase its size. Performing strength training with increasing difficulty is how muscle is built. The more muscle you have, the more "toned" you will look with a certain level of body fat.

FAQ 3) Can I build muscle and lose fat at the same time?

Yes. This can actually be done at an appreciable rate if you fit into any of the criteria below:

- 1) Complete beginner to consistent resistance training
- 2) Returning to consistent resistance training after a long break
- 3) Overweight/Obese, or a lot of fat to lose in general
- 4) Pharmaceutical loopholes (i.e., PEDs)

If you're more experienced with **consistent** resistance training and don't fit into the criteria above, it is still possible to build muscle and lose fat at the same time. However, you must accept that building muscle will occur at a **much slower** rate than if you were eating in a calorie surplus. This is why it's important to lose fat at a steady, sustainable rate if you are in a fat-loss phase, so that you still have sufficient energy to progress in your workouts. However, don't expect to put on any muscle in a calorie deficit if you are 10% body fat. If you try to get too lean, you will feel awful. There will come a point when your body simply will not let you build any more muscle until you eat more.

If you are a beginner and/or a teenager, **and you don't have a lot of body fat to lose**, there is no real reason for you to eat in a calorie deficit if building muscle is a priority for you. Eating at maintenance calories, or in a slight surplus will be better for you.

FAQ 4) Should I perform cardio?

Whether your goal is to bulk or cut, doing some form of cardio will be beneficial for you. Whether you play a sport, go for walks, or do circuit training. Choose a form of cardio that suits your schedule, and that you enjoy. This is for overall heart health, as well as building work capacity. Just be wary of how you manage it. Things you must consider include intensity, timing, and frequency. For high-intensity interval training, do no more than 40mins total per week (20mins if you already frequently play in intense sport). You can spread it out how you like. Just ensure to do it as far as possible from your weight training sessions (e.g. on a rest day), or only **after** the main weight training session if you do both on the same day. Low intensity cardio can be performed more frequently, for longer periods of time since it is less taxing on recovery. Daily 30-60min walks can go a long way for overall health.

FAQ 5) My muscles feel sore. Is this normal? Will I still build muscle if muscle if I don't get sore?

Soreness is a normal part of training, especially when you're a beginner. As you adapt, the soreness should gradually start to fade away. Therefore, I recommend being more conservative with your total volume when you start training, so that you give your body time to adapt. Additionally, be sensible with your weight selections (i.e., don't ego lift!) when you start, and implement a **very gradual** progression scheme in your training. More details of this are in chapter 4. Make sure you are adequately warmed up before your session to help if you feel sore.

Many people believe that if their workouts don't make them sore, the workout did not stimulate any muscle growth. This could not be further from the truth. Soreness can indicate that the muscles were introduced to a stimulus that they are not used to, but more soreness

doesn't necessarily equate to more muscle growth. For example, going for a jog can make your legs very sore if you're not used to it, but will stimulate little/no muscle growth, due to the nature of the exercise. If your soreness from resistance training reduces over time, this is good news as it indicates that the muscles are adapting to handling increased stress.

FAQ6) Is training for strength different from training for hypertrophy (muscle growth)?

For the most part, **no**. "Strength", in general, is the ability to produce force. The more force you can exert, the more load you can lift. If you get stronger within a variety of rep ranges (e.g. 4 – 6, 5 – 8, 6 – 10, 8 – 12), your muscles will grow. Ensure to select appropriate loads for the different rep ranges, where good technique can be applied. As already mentioned, **strength** is the ability to lift more load. **Hypertrophy** refers to increasing muscle **size**. Strength and muscle size are two traits that complement each other. The training methodologies for each trait can be thought of as a spectrum. The lowest rep ranges (e.g., 1 – 5) will be more specific for strength (i.e. **maximal strength**), but will build some muscle. With hypertrophy, there are many factors that contribute to it. Strength (i.e. more load) is only one of the factors that can contribute to muscle growth, with volume (i.e. the number of reps/sets) and effort (difficulty of the set) being other important contributing factors. Whilst you can build muscle in any rep range, the 5 – 12 rep range allows for efficient accumulation of volume, hence being more "specific" for muscle growth, while still slightly contributing slightly to "maximal" strength (i.e. strength in the 1 – 5 rep range). **Strength and size complement each other.** A bigger muscle has more strength potential, and if you improve strength, you can handle more weight for the higher rep sets, hence contributing to muscle growth. Think of it as a never-ending cycle.

FAQ 7) What is the best way to organise my workout split?

The one that suits your schedule, and you enjoy. Generally, it should allow you to perform hard training for each muscle group at least twice per week, but anything can work if you are consistent, and exercise selection is reasonable.

FAQ 8) Why are there back exercises on lower body days in the sample program?

Three reasons.

- 1) Firstly, the upper back muscles and lats tend to be more resilient and can tolerate a little more volume than other body parts. Therefore, the back may benefit from a bit more work so that each individual muscle can get a sufficient stimulus.
- 2) Vertical pulls (Pull-ups, lat pull-downs) work well on leg days. They can help decompress the spine after performing sets of heavy compound lower body exercises which load the spine. I've personally found that pull-ups feel great after heavy sets of squats or deadlifts. When doing vertical pulls, emphasise a deep stretch (e.g., dead-hang on pull-ups or full stretch at the top of a lat pull-down). **Let me emphasise, I AM NOT A DOCTOR NOR PHYSIOTHERAPIST. If you have chronic back pain, speak to an appropriately qualified professional.**

- 3) Most people who train overemphasise the “show muscles” at the front of the body (chest, front delts) while neglecting the back of the body (e.g., back, rear delts). This can lead to muscle imbalances and postural issues, so frequent back training can help to counter this common habit.

FAQ 9) Why is there only one vertical push per week in the sample program?

The front delts get significant work on both horizontal and vertical pushes. However, the chest is not significantly worked in vertical pushes. Therefore, there is a bias towards horizontal pushes in the program. Note that the incline bench press can be considered a hybrid of horizontal and vertical pushing. You can replace one horizontal push with a vertical push, but I’d recommend having no less than 2 horizontal pushes per week and a minimum of one vertical push per week.

FAQ 10) I’ve been running my program for a while and I want to switch things up. What do I do?

See chapter 4.8, under the subheading “After 12 weeks, what next?” on page 37.

FAQ 11) How do I know when I am an intermediate lifter?

There is no magic time frame to say when you move from beginner to intermediate. The simplest way to describe it is when progress begins to slow down significantly after a period of regular resistance training (e.g., only able to add weight/reps monthly instead of weekly/fortnightly). Typically, this occurs anywhere between 6 months and 2 years of **CONTINUOUS** training with no long breaks. If you stall in progress in performance in your first couple of months, you need to evaluate factors outside the gym such as nutrition (are you eating right? Are you eating enough?) and recovery (are you sleeping enough?) before considering a more complex form of progression.

FAQ 12) Why are there so many giant sets/supersets in the sample program?

This is to act as a time-saving tool. You can squeeze more exercises in a shorter time window. Smaller, single-joint/isolation movements are not as fatiguing, and supersets work very well for these. However, I don’t recommend doing this with compound lower body movements (E.g., squats and deadlifts), unless you do it with a smaller movement that doesn’t interfere (e.g., superset of squats and lateral raises). Compound lower body movements are the most technical and work better if they get the time dedicated to them that they require. You can use supersets with some upper body movements. For example, push/pull supersets (e.g. bench press and dumbbell row) can work well, if you wish to save even more time. Supersets and giant sets can also aid in developing cardiovascular conditioning and overall work capacity.

FAQ 13) Why is there no front delt isolation work?

The front delts already get plenty of stimulation from all the pushing. Most people tend to overdevelop the front delts compared to the rear delts when training, which can lead to a “hunched” posture. For shoulder health, pushing and pulling volume should be at least equal. Performing more pulling than pushing may be beneficial for some people.

Chapter 1: The Basics (Nutrition, Recovery, Mindset)

*You'll reach 90% of your full muscle-building potential just by **consistently** getting these basics right. A muscle needs 5 things for it to grow.*

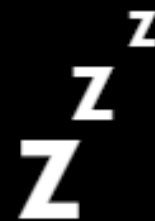
1) Stimulus



The “stimulus” is your weight training. A progressive stimulus is required to trigger a muscle to grow. When you perform challenging resistance training, it is interpreted as a threat by your body. Your muscles will adapt and grow to be more prepared for that “threat” (and maybe a little more) the next time. In other words, you need to give your muscles a reason to grow. To continuously stimulate growth, you need to give the muscles a progressively more difficult stimulus to deal with, which they will gradually adapt to. See chapter 4.4 for more information on **progressive overload**.

2) Rest

Aim for an absolute minimum of 7 hours of sleep per night (ideally more). This goes without saying. Your muscles need an opportunity to grow and repair after they undergo stress. This becomes more important the stronger you get. If you don't sleep, you don't recover. If you're not recovered, you'll be less able to progress in your workouts, thus slowing down the muscle-building process.



3) Energy



Food is fuel. You need sufficient energy to perform well in your workouts. Calories come from carbohydrates, fats, and protein. The process of building and repairing muscle also requires energy. For the most efficient muscle gain, eating in a slight calorie surplus will serve you well. This means you consume slightly more energy than your body burns. A good starting point is to eat around 10% more

than your maintenance calories. For example, if you eat around 2500 calories to stay at the same weight, a good starting point for a calorie surplus would be $2500 + 250 = 2750$ calories. Remember to be sensible with your surplus. Many people use this as an excuse to overindulge in junk food. This is pointless. You'll end up gaining excessive fat. Health still comes first. A small surplus will be enough. **However**, if you have a large amount of body fat, you have enough energy stored in reserves, so you can build muscle at an appreciable rate while eating in a slight calorie deficit. Otherwise, a calorie surplus would be beneficial. If you are a beginner, you may get away with eating at a calorie maintenance for a while. See **FAQ3** on page 6 for more details on building muscle and losing fat at the same time.

4) Protein

Protein provides the raw materials needed to repair muscles and build new muscle tissue. If building muscle is a priority for you, a good target to aim for is to consume around 1.5 – 2 grams of protein per kg of body weight each day, spread out across multiple meals [4]. For example, if you weighed 70kg, you would aim for a range of 105 – 140 grams of protein per day. You can get away with being in the lower end of the range if you are eating in a calorie surplus [4]. If you are in a calorie deficit, or you regularly play a sport on top of weight training, you may wish to consume towards the higher end of the range (or slightly above) [4]. For some heavier individuals, this may be too difficult to achieve, from a practical standpoint. An alternative would be 1 gram of protein per cm height. Good sources of protein include lean meat, poultry, fish, eggs, beans, and lentils.



5) Water

Hydrate. Hydrate. Hydrate. Did I mention that you should hydrate? It seems obvious but is often neglected. Drink at least 2 litres of water per day, plus an additional litre for every hour of intense exercise you do. Water accounts for roughly 75% of muscle mass, and it helps deliver nutrients around the body. In the context of muscle growth, water helps deliver the nutrients required for building new muscle [5].

Mindset: “How do I stay motivated to train?”

Forgive me for the cliché, but **don't rely on motivation**. In fitness, you **won't** get far if you only train on days when you feel like it. A practical tip which might help is to have concrete medium-term goals which build towards general long-term goals. For example, “I want to increase my bench press by 15kg, with good technique, in the next 12 weeks (medium-term). This will help build my chest (long-term).” With an objective goal in mind, it can help provide that “push”. You'll be less likely to skip the gym on a whim. You will know in the back of your mind that skipping the session will only put you back. How I think about it is: “Skipping would

only delay me reaching this goal. So, what's the point of me skipping today's scheduled session, just because I don't feel like it?" Continuous concrete goals will help with long-term consistency. Give it a few weeks, and you'll fall in love with the process.

Chapter 2: Major Muscle Groups

The purpose of this section is to give you an idea of what muscles you should be feeling in each movement. You don't need to memorise the muscle names.

Approximate regions of the muscle locations have been highlighted. Please note that these are **approximations** of where certain muscles are located.



Pectoralis major, "Pecs", Location: Chest



Obliques, Location: Abdomen



Rectus Abdominis, "Abs", Location: Abdomen



Forearm Flexors and Extensors



Anterior Deltoids, "Front delts"
Location: (Front) Shoulder



Biceps Brachii, "Biceps" Location: Upper Arm



Lateral Deltoids, "Side delts" Location: (Side) Shoulder



Triceps Brachii, "Triceps", Location: Upper Arm



Erector Spinae, "Spinal Erectors" Location: Runs along the centre, from the lower to upper back



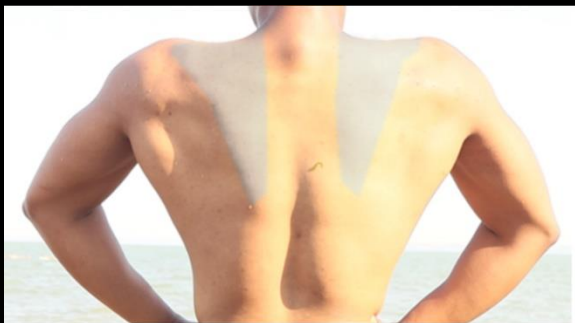
Rhomboids, Location: Central Upper Back



Latissimus Dorsi, "Lats" Location: Sides of the mid to lower back.



Teres Major, Location: Sides of the upper back



Trapezius, "Traps" Location: Upper to mid back



Quadriceps, "Quads" Location: Front Thigh



Posterior deltoids, “Rear delts” Location:
Back of the shoulders



Gastrocnemius and Soleus, “Calves”
Location: Back of the lower leg



Hamstrings, Location: Back of the thighs



Gluteus Maximus, Medius and Minimus,
Location: Buttocks (between hips and thighs)

SEE MUSCLE FUNCTIONS ON THE NEXT TWO PAGES

	Functions	Example Exercises
Body part		
Chest	Moving the arms across the body from the sides to centre, elevating the arms frontwards (upper chest), lowering arms from the side (Lower chest)	Flat bench press (Dumbbell and Barbell), Incline bench press (Dumbbell and Barbell), Dips, Chest flys (Machine or dumbbell variations)
Back	Lats: Lowering arms from the side, moving arms behind you (elbows towards hip) Teres muscles: Lowering arms from the side, moving arms behind you Traps: Shrugging, lowering the shoulders, squeezing the shoulder blades (The <u>rhomboids</u> also contribute to squeezing the shoulder blade), extending/rotating the neck. Spinal Erectors: Maintaining or moving to an upright posture	<u>Vertical Pulls</u> Pull-ups (Neutral grip, overhand or underhand grip) of varied grip widths, lat pull downs (Neutral grip, overhand or underhand grip) <u>Horizontal Pulls</u> Barbell or Dumbbell rows, machine rows <u>Hinges</u> Deadlifts, Romanian Deadlifts (RDL) (Barbell or Dumbbell), hyperextensions, goodmornings
Legs (Thighs)	Quads: Extending the leg Hamstrings: Curling the leg, extending the hips	<u>Quads</u> Squats, Lunges, Leg extensions <u>Hamstrings</u> Deadlifts, Romanian Deadlifts, Goodmornings, Leg Curls, hyperextensions
Legs (Calves)	Points the toes away from you	Any calf raise movement
Buttocks	Glutes Extend the hip, rotate the hip	Deadlifts, Romanian Deadlifts, hip thrusts, hip abduction machine
Shoulders	<u>Front delts</u> Elevate the arms forwards <u>Side Delts</u> Elevate the arms to the side <u>Rear Delts</u> Moving arms from the centre to the sides of the body, moving the arms behind you	<u>Front delts</u> Vertical shoulder presses (Barbell, Dumbbell or machine), Horizontal presses <u>Side delts</u> Lateral Raises (Dumbbell or machine variations), vertical shoulder presses <u>Rear delts</u> Rows, Rear delt flys (dumbbell or machine variations), skiers, Face Pulls

Arms	Triceps: Extending the arm, moving arms behind the body Biceps: Bending the arms, turning the palms to face up Forearm muscles: Bending the wrist, bending the arm, gripping objects	<u>Triceps</u> Triceps extensions (machine or dumbbell variations), skull crushers (Barbell or dumbbell variations), bench-press movement, vertical pushing movements <u>Biceps</u> Standard barbell/dumbbell curls, hammer curls <u>Forearm muscles</u> Hammer curls, wrist curls, wrist extensions, reverse grip curls
Core	<u>Abs:</u> Flex the spine (forwards), stabilise the trunk, maintain posture <u>Obliques:</u> Flex the spine laterally (bend torso to the side), rotate the torso	<u>Abs</u> Crunches, leg/knee raises, Planks <u>Obliques</u> Planks, Russian oblique twists

Chapter 3: Key Terms

Don't worry. You don't need to memorise these. Give it a few months, and a lot of these will be part of your everyday vocabulary. This section is to act as a reference.

<u>AMRAP</u> As many reps as possible.	<u>Callisthenics</u> Bodyweight focussed movements.	<u>Concentric</u> Muscle shortening phase of the lift. E.g., Pushing the weight up on a bench-press.	<u>Calorie Deficit</u> Consuming less calories than you burn.	<u>Calorie Maintenance</u> Calories required fulfil energy requirements, and maintain weight.
<u>Calorie Surplus</u> Consuming more calories than you burn.	<u>Delayed-Onset-Muscle-Soreness (DOMS):</u> This is soreness that will be felt in the muscles a day or two after intense weight training. It is normal, and should reduce as your body adapts.	<u>Compound Exercise:</u> Multi-joint exercise which uses multiple muscle groups at a time (E.g., Bench press, Squat, Pull-up).	<u>Eccentric:</u> Muscle lengthening phase of the lift: E.g., lowering phase of the squat, lowering bicep curl, moving arms up on a lat pull-down.	<u>Failure</u> Inability to perform any more reps with the same form. E.g., "Do the last set until you reach failure."

<u>Frequency</u> Refers to the number of times per week a certain muscle group/movement pattern is worked.	<u>Isolation Exercise:</u> Single-joint exercise, typically focusing on a single muscle group (e.g., Lateral raises, bicep curls).	<u>Isometric:</u> Muscle contracting without changing in length (e.g., abs in a plank).	<u>Progressive overload:</u> Progressively making training more difficult through manipulation of variables: Weight, reps, and sets.	<u>Giant Set</u> A cycle of 3 or more exercises is performed with no rest in between them. For example, crunches, straight into bicep curls then straight into lateral raises without rest in between them.
<u>Range of Motion</u> A joint/muscle's ability to move through a distance on a specific path.	<u>Hypertrophy</u> Enlargement of tissue, E.g., Muscle growth.	<u>Sets:</u> Number of cycles completed of a certain number of repetitions. E.g., 3 sets x 8 reps = performing 8 continuous reps, 3 times with breaks between each round.	<u>Volume:</u> The total amount of work performed by a muscle group. It can be described as total sets x reps x weights x distance, or more simply described as the total number of challenging sets for a muscle group.	<u>"Junk Volume"</u> Additional sets/exercises performed with no significant additional benefit for building muscle.

<u>Repetitions (“Reps”):</u> Number of times a movement is performed. E.g., 8 reps of bicep curls = curling a weight 8 times continuously.	<u>Stabiliser Muscles:</u> Muscles which act to provide overall balance and stability to a movement (e.g., Abs and glute medius in a squat)	<u>Training Split:</u> The organisation of training within the week. For example, a “4-day split” would include 4 weight training days per week.	<u>Warm-up sets:</u> Sets performed with very light weights before the main working sets, to prepare the muscles, joints and tendons for a specific movement.	<u>Work Capacity</u> The total amount of work you can perform and recover from.
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Chapter 4: Structure your first program

4.1. Compound Exercises and Fundamental Movement Patterns

Compound exercises should be the foundation of your routine. They are multi-joint exercises which use multiple muscle groups. This makes them efficient since they activate larger amounts of muscle mass compared to isolation lifts. Compound movements should be performed before isolation exercises within workouts since they are more physically demanding and technical, and therefore you want to hit them in a fresh state.

Compound exercises can be grouped into 7 categories. These are fundamental movement patterns.

- 1) **Squats** (E.g., Barbell back squat, goblet squat, front squat). Squats mainly work the **quadriceps and the glutes**. You can find squat movements in **section 1 of the exercise library**.



- 2) **Lunges** (Bulgarian split squats, step-ups, lateral lunges, walking lunges). Lunges mainly work the **quadriceps and the glutes**. You can find lunges in **section 2 of the exercise library**.



- 3) **Hip hinges** (E.g., Deadlift, Romanian deadlift, glute bridge, hip thrust hyperextensions). Hip hinges mainly use the hamstrings, glutes, and spinal erectors. You can find hip hinge movements in **section 3 of the exercise library**.



- 4) **Horizontal Pushes** (E.g., Barbell/Dumbbell bench press, incline barbell/dumbbell bench press, chest press machine, push-ups). Horizontal pushes work the chest, triceps, and shoulders. **See section 4 of the exercise library**.



- 5) **Horizontal Pulls** (E.g., Barbell rows, dumbbell rows, cable rows, inverted rows). Horizontal pulls work the back, biceps, and shoulders. **See section 5 of the exercise library**.



- 6) **Vertical Pushes** (E.g., Barbell military press, dumbbell shoulder press, machine shoulder press). Vertical pushes mainly work the shoulders and the triceps. **See section 6 of the exercise library.**



- 7) **Vertical Pulls** (E.g., Pull-ups, chin-ups, lat pull-downs). Vertical pulls work the back and the biceps. **See section 7 of the exercise library).**



TLDR: “Compound exercises should be the foundation of your routine. They are multi-joint exercises which use multiple muscle groups.”

4.2. Isolation Exercises

Isolation exercises should also be included in your program. You may come across two extreme schools of thought on this topic as you search the depths of YouTube fitness.



There is one school of thought that believes isolation exercises are pointless and should be skipped altogether. The problem with this minimalistic approach is that it may leave smaller muscle groups underdeveloped in the long term. For example, the biceps, triceps, calves, and abs. They may get some good stimulation from compound lifts (i.e., assisting bigger muscle groups in compound movements), and even see significant growth in the beginning stages of lifting. However, their development will not be maximised by solely relying on compound movements. Additionally, this minimalism may lead to muscle imbalances, overuse, and ultimately increased injury risk.

The opposite extreme school of thought promotes an excessive amount of isolation lifts (e.g., Your typical TikTok routine with 10 different types of bicep curls in a workout), with little/no emphasis on compounds. Many routines you may see on Bodybuilding.com, or TikTok are designed by influencers who have access to certain pharmaceutical loopholes. The problem with excessive isolation lifts for the average trainee is that they may induce unwarranted fatigue with diminishing returns. There are only so many variations of bicep curls that you can do before it turns into junk volume.



Like many things, the answer lies somewhere in the middle. A good general guideline to follow is to have 80% of training time be dedicated to compound exercises to cover your base, and the other 20% (Yes, I know, *sigh* 'another 80/20 rule') be dedicated to isolation movements as the icing on the cake. Please don't overthink this. Prioritise your compound movements by doing them first, and then supplement them with isolations.

Isolation exercises do have value for aesthetic-focused, strength-focused, and recreational trainees alike. For example, improving aesthetic proportions, joint health, injury

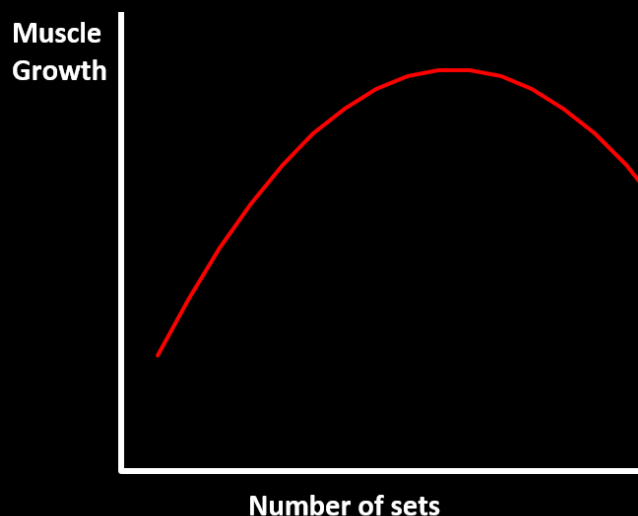
prevention, fixing weaknesses and improving leverages for big lifts.

TLDR:

“Prioritise your compound movements by doing them first, and then supplement them with isolations.”

4.3 Volume - How many total sets per week is optimal for muscle growth?

Volume is simply the amount of total work you do. The simplest way to think of it is the **total number of challenging sets that you perform for each muscle group**. So how many sets should we do each week? If you’re new to fitness, you need to get used to the answer, “it depends”, which applies here. **There is no concrete number**. The appropriate number of weekly sets will vary between individuals, since we all have different recovery capabilities, and available time to train in the gym. Therefore, you will just have to find that number over time as you gain experience over the years. Generally, more hard sets will stimulate more muscle growth, **but only up to a point** in the real world. Above a certain threshold, adding extra sets starts to yield diminishing returns and eventually becomes counter-productive due to the added recovery demands (assuming the sets are reasonably challenging) [9].



Recent scientific literature suggests that **10 – 20 challenging working sets per muscle group per week** [9] is a good “sweet spot” (**WARM UP SETS ARE NOT COUNTED IN THIS**). Now, after reading this, your instinct is telling you to do 20 sets for every muscle group in your routine from the jump. More sets = more gains, right? **RELAX**. If you are into the evidence-based side of fitness, you can’t take studies at face value. Studies are valuable and have their place, but there are many things to consider. How experienced are the test subjects? How hard are they training? Are there multiple studies supporting this? What’s the sample size? Who funded the study? Yes, sometimes there may be a financial incentive to push a certain claim in a study, even if it’s not accurate. This is too common in the (corrupt) fitness supplements industry. Rant over. Back to the point about sets per week. Not every exercise is created equal. A set of leg extensions will not provide the same stimulus for your quads, nor induce the same level of fatigue as a set of heavy

squats. 10 – 20 sets is a decent ballpark figure, but many studies don’t consider how hard people are training, or even how specific muscle groups respond to certain exercises. It can be tempting to do 20 sets per muscle group per week from the start, after reading those numbers from the studies. Again, **RELAX**. If you are a beginner to **consistent** weight training, you are the most primed for muscle growth that you will ever be. Weight training is a very novel stimulus for your body, meaning that you can make very significant progress while training towards the lower end of the volume range. Eventually, you can start gradually increasing volume over time if needed. Starting from the highest possible volume may not always be the best idea from a practical standpoint. Firstly, the **soreness** in the following days will be worse than it needs to be, meaning that it can impair performance in subsequent workouts. Soreness is normal, but the higher volume approach at the start (**especially as a beginner**) may unnecessarily elevate it. Secondly, **form degradation** is more likely to occur if the volume is too high. This would be more pronounced with beginners who are still yet to learn proper exercise technique. This can ingrain long-term, poor technique habits if not addressed.

Now while there is no single concrete number of sets, I understand that people need somewhere to start. Decent, practical **starting points for beginners** can be found in the table below:

Large Muscle Groups – (E.g., Chest, Back, Quads, Hamstrings, Glutes)	8 – 12 <u>hard</u> sets per week
Smaller Muscle Groups (E.g., Biceps, Triceps, Calves, Abs)	5 – 10 <u>hard</u> sets per week (from smaller/isolation movements)

I must stress again: **THESE DO NOT INCLUDE WARM-UP SETS**. Only **working sets** are counted when looking at the total weekly volume.

For larger muscle groups, most of the sets should come from compound exercises, as these will stimulate the most growth. Note that there will be some overlap with smaller muscle groups. For example, the triceps will support your chest and shoulders in pushing exercises (bench press, military press), the biceps will support the back in pulling movements (E.g., Pull-ups, rows, lat-pull downs) and the abs act as stabilisers in many compound exercises of different types (E.g., squat, deadlifts, military press). However, some additional direct work for the smaller muscle groups through smaller lifts is still needed if you want to maximise growth. Therefore, the “5-10” weekly set guideline refers specifically to **direct isolation/single-joint exercises** for smaller muscle groups. This recommendation assumes you are also frequently performing big compound movements on top of this.

4.4 Progression Methods (IMPORTANT!)

“Progressive overload” is just a fancy term which describes making training more difficult over time. This increases the stress on your muscles over time, which they will gradually adapt to (i.e., they’ll grow). You **must** have a plan of progression integrated into your program. This is **non-negotiable** if

you are looking to build muscle. Strength and muscle size are inseparable, **especially as a beginner**. Therefore, setting yourself performance targets will allow you to build muscle as a by-product. Examples of performance targets for you to use include:

- Performing the same number sets and reps with the same weight, with improved form (e.g., improved range of motion and/or control of the weight).
- Performing the same weight and number sets with more reps per set than previously **WITH GOOD, CONSISTENT FORM**
- Performing the same number of sets and reps with more weight than previously **WITH GOOD, CONSISTENT FORM**
- Performing more sets than previously with the same weight and reps per set **WITH GOOD, CONSISTENT FORM**

When you first start training, focusing on improving technique (especially on the compound exercises) can be valuable, and a very legitimate form of progressive overload, even if the weight stays the same for the first 2-3 weeks. Adding weight with a degrading technique does not count as progress. After learning the technique, assuming you've had good practice with the form on the exercises, you should push to make the exercises more challenging to continue stimulating muscle growth. This is where progression schemes become important.

There are **three** progression schemes I recommend for beginners to serious weight training. These are double progression, dynamic double progression, and the rep goal system. Don't worry. They are much simpler than the names suggest. You are simply setting rules for yourself which dictate when you are allowed to/should add weight.

4.4.1 – Double Progression

Double progression means that you are trying to progress with two variables at a time. Reps and weight. In my opinion, it's the most intuitive way of training and a simple way for beginners to get started.

The number of sets is fixed, and you use the same weight for all working sets.

- 1) Firstly, choose your number of sets, and rep range. For example, this can be **3 sets** of 5 - 8 reps.
- 2) Start with a sensible weight that will allow you to work within that rep range with proper technique. It should be doable, and somewhat challenging (If you struggle to hit the bottom end of the rep range on the first set in the first 2-3 weeks, you started too heavy and should lower the weight).

- 3) You should aim to complete **3 sets of the upper end of the rep range**. For example, if the rep range is 5 – 8 reps, you should aim to complete 8 reps on all 3 sets.
- 4) If you manage to complete step 3 successfully, you should add weight by the **smallest possible increment** next week. For example, adding 2.5kg/5lbs TOTAL (1.25kg/2.5lbs plate each side) to the bar the next week on a barbell squat, or using the next heaviest set of dumbbells on a dumbbell shoulder press.
- 5) If one session, you are unable to complete all 3 sets of the upper end of the rep range, you would aim to increase the reps from the previous week, keeping the weight the same. Increasing by even just one total rep across 3 sets is progress. **Celebrate every small win.**

**Example: Barbell Bench press 3 sets of 5 – 8
reps, Double Progression**

Week 1
40kg x 8 8 8

Week 2
42.5kg x 8 8 8

Week 3
45kg x 8 8 8

Week 4
47.5kg x 8 8 7

Week 5
47.5kg x 8 8 8

Week 6
50kg x 8 6 6

Week 7
50kg x 8 7 6

This is still progress!

4.4.2 – Rep goal System

This is very similar to the conventional double progression, described above. I learnt this method from Steve Shaw, from the Massive Iron Channel. With the rep goal system, you are still looking to progress in reps before adding weight. However, in this instance, progression is dictated by the **total reps** accumulated across all sets, rather than each individual set. The number of sets is kept **fixed** from week to week. You will then set yourself a TOTAL REP GOAL across all sets.

- 1) Firstly, choose the number of sets you wish to do, and set your total rep goal for

those sets. For example, 3 sets of bicep curls, with a total rep goal of 40. This can be anything you like.

- 2) In each set, perform as many quality reps as possible (close to failure) with proper technique. Stop the set when you are unable to perform any more reps with good form. Do this for multiple sets.
- 3) Add up the total number of reps completed across all sets. If it adds up to the rep total or more, weight should be added (by the smallest possible increment) the next time you perform the exercise.
- 4) If you are unable to reach the rep goal, aim to complete more reps in the next session until the total rep goal is reached. See the example below.

Example: EZ-bar Bicep Curls: 3 sets, rep goal 40 reps

Week 1

20kg x 16 14 12 (Total = 42)

Week 2

22.5kg x 16 13 11 (Total = 40)

Week 3

25kg x 14 12 10 (Total = 36)

Week 4

25kg x 15 13 10 (Total = 38)

Week 5

25kg x 16 13 11 (Total = 40)

Week 6

27.5kg x 14 12 11 (Total = 37)

Week 7

27.5kg x 15 12 11 (Total = 38)

In your early weeks/months of training, I would limit the rep goal system to smaller **isolation exercises**, **machine exercises** or **bodyweight movements**. Every set is an **AMRAP** set (i.e., very close to complete muscular failure) with the rep goal method, which is where form breakdown can potentially become an issue. These movements are less technical and have less of a learning curve compared to free weight compound exercises. The total rep goal can be any number you like, but the minimum should be 8

reps per set plus one (e.g., for 2 sets, your rep goal total should be 17 or above. For 3 sets, 25 or above and so on).

If you wish to use the rep goal system with free weighted compound exercises, I would recommend applying the rep goal system for them only after you've had a few months practising them with other progression schemes (e.g., double progression), so you learn good technique habits.

The rep-goal system and double progression are also explained in this YouTube resource:
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nDbptrxnWVA&t=33s>

4.4.3 – Dynamic Double Progression

I learnt this from Sean Nalewanyj. This is a LOT simpler than it sounds. Think of it as double progression that went to private school. This allows you to continue to drive strength progression and apply similar effort in all sets. The steps are explained below:

- 1) Keeping the **number of sets fixed**, choose a suitable weight that will allow you to work within the specified rep range. For example, 3 sets of 8 – 12 reps. You will use the same weight across all sets if you are able to stay within the rep range.
- 2) Use the same weight on all sets within that session (assuming you are within the specified rep range). However, **if you perform the lower end of the rep range (or less) on any set**, reduce the weight for the next set within that same session.
- 3) **If you can perform the upper end of the rep range on a first set, you would increase the weight by the smallest possible increment in the following week for that exercise.** Otherwise, keep the weight the same for that set the next week, and apply the same rules as described in step 2. If that's confusing, the example below should make things clear.

Example: Dumbbell (DB) Bench Press, 8
– 12 rep range, Dynamic Double
Progression

Week 1

**Set 1: 20kg DB x12, Set 2: 20kg DB x12 Set 3:
20kg DB x11**

Week 2

**Set 1: 22kg DB x12, Set 2: 22kg DB x11, Set 3:
22kg DB x11**

Week 3

**Set 1: 24kg DB x10, Set 2: 24kg DB x8, Set 3:
22kg DB x9**

Week 4

**Set 1: 24kg DB x10, Set 2: 24kg, DB x9 Set 3:
24kg DB x8**

Week 5

**Set 1: 24kg DB x12, Set 2: 24kg, DB x10 Set 3:
24kg DB x8**

Week 6

**Set 1: 26kg DB x10, Set 2: 26kg, DB x8, Set 3:
24kg DB x10**

4.5 How many days per week should you train?



(Image Source: [3])

This will depend on your individual ability to recover from training which is largely dictated by your schedule.

You don't have to weight train every day of the week for hours on end to see results. Having a few days outside of the weight room will be beneficial for you to allow for **recovery**, focus on other hobbies, other aspects of fitness (e.g., cardio), and other areas of life in general.

Many people commit to a 6-day per week program for the first 3 weeks of January and don't touch the gym until next January approaches. My advice would be to pick a split that

you can **realistically** stay consistent with while fitting it in with your schedule. Fitness is a lifelong commitment. Not a 90-day challenge. The person who trains 3 days per week for a year will see greater results than the person who trains 6 days per week for a month. Not to say there is anything wrong with 6-day-a-week training, but I would advise that to be something you build up to over months once you are more acclimated to resistance training and/or the gym in general. There are even top-level powerlifters and bodybuilders who have had great success weight training with 3-4-day training splits.

4.6 – What is the best Training Split?

You guessed it - It depends! The best training split is one that you can stick to **consistently**. The person who is consistent with an 8/10 program will get more results than the person who is inconsistent with a 10/10 program. I'd recommend starting with a routine that allows you to train within the volume ranges (See section 4.3), while training each body part at least twice per week. This will allow for a larger number of high-quality sets for each body part per week. However, the best split is one that you can stay consistent with and ultimately enjoy. Examples of popular training splits for the gym can be found below:

4.6.1 – 3 days per week – Full Body

Here, you are training both upper and lower body in the same session, 3 days per week. Many people believe this to be reserved for beginners only, or for people who just want to "keep fit" and aren't serious about building muscle. However, this could not be further from the truth. Full-body training was actually very popular amongst top-tier "Bronze" and "Silver-era" bodybuilders in the 30s and 40s, and early 50s when performance-enhancing drugs were not as common in the bodybuilding world as they are today. This era saw arguably some of the best natural bodybuilders. I frequently revert to full body during busy periods of life, and have had great success with it.

Typical Layout:

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thurs	Fri	Sat	Sun
Full Body 1	Rest	Full Body 2	Rest	Full Body 3	Rest	Rest

Pros:

- 4 days of rest and recovery throughout the week
- Flexible: If you miss one day, you've still got two quality sessions in the week. Additionally, you can easily move days around if needed.
- You can train each body part with more intensity per session since the work for each body part is spread out between 3 sessions. Therefore, the average quality of work for each muscle group will be high, since the muscles will be fresher. Furthermore, this enables practising movement patterns more often.
- Encourages a focus on compound exercises.
- Some of you may be glad to hear that you never have to do a full-blown leg day
- After the first couple of weeks or so, each body part will have less soreness.
- Workouts are intense, but full body training is great for developing **work capacity**.

Cons:

- Longer Sessions: You need to warm up multiple body parts within the session. Additionally, you need to fit in more exercise per session.
- Each body part gets less of a "pump" in each workout
- You may have to deal with soreness between sessions. Volume, exercise selection and order must therefore be carefully managed.
- May be hard to fit in volume for smaller muscle groups

4.6.2 – 4 days per week – Lower Body/Upper Body

This is what it says on the tin. You focus on the lower body (i.e., Legs) on some days and the upper body (Chest, Back, Arms, Shoulders) on other days. You can train abs on either upper or lower days, or even rest days (but I wouldn't recommend training abs too intensely the day before a lower body day).

Typical setup:

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thurs	Fri	Sat	Sun
Lower Body 1	Upper Body 1	Rest	Lower Body 2	Upper Body 2	Rest	Rest

Pros:

- Intuitive setup
- Chest + back pumped together is amazing. You look huge at the end of the session
- Can fit more volume per session per body part (compared to full body).
- Volume for each body part split into 2 sessions per week – high average set quality, and gain technique practice with certain movement patterns.
- Flexible: Can move around days if needed. Just ensure to have at least three rest days per 7-day period, and no more than two consecutive sessions.
- Can fit conveniently within the work week. 3 days of full rest and recovery.

Cons:

- Upper body sessions may be longer, due to many muscle groups to train.
- May be hard to fit in volume for smaller muscle groups.

4.6.3 – 5 days per week – Body part Split (“Bro Split”)

This method gained popularity in the 60s. Essentially, you split it up into days based on body parts, and blast one muscle group (maybe 2) once per week. In recent years, the bro-split has been under fire, commonly seen as a sub-optimal way to train the body. Whilst it wouldn't be my personal first choice, the bro-split can work if you are consistent, and exercises are arranged appropriately. Remember, if you work hard, emphasise progressive overload, have a reasonable exercise selection and are consistent, anything can work great.

Mon (International chest day)	Tue	Wed	Thurs	Fri	Sat	Sun
Chest (+maybe triceps)	Back (+Maybe Biceps)	Legs	Shoulders	Arms	Rest	Rest

Pros:

- A lot of people find this method fun. Who doesn't love getting a huge pump in one body part? The best program is one you are willing to stick to, and enjoyment is an important factor in staying consistent.
- Shorter sessions: fewer warm-ups are needed for exercises later in the workout
- Encourages hard work
- Full week of recovery for each muscle group

Cons:

- May take longer for muscle soreness after workouts to reduce, since you are blasting each body part once per week.
- It can encourage “junk volume”. Once your muscles are fatigued later on in the workout, the remaining sets you do may not be as productive.
- Some body parts might be neglected. It can create a bad relationship with certain training days. For example, many lifters hate leg day and would be tempted to skip it.
- Not as flexible as other splits. If you miss a session, you may not hit that body part for the whole week.

4.6.4 – 6 days per week – Legs Push Pull

This has been probably the most popular split in recent years. You split the upper body muscles based on body actions: Pushing and pulling, and the legs get their own dedicated days of training. A typical setup can be shown below:

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thurs	Fri	Sat	Sun
Legs (Quads, Hamstrings, Glutes, Calves)	Push (Chest, Triceps, Shoulders)	Pull (Back, Biceps, Shoulders)	Legs (Quads, Hamstrings, Glutes, Calves)	Push (Chest, Triceps, Shoulders)	Pull (Back, Biceps, Shoulders)	Rest

Pros:

- Same enjoyment factor as the bro split: Everyone enjoys pumps.
- Shorter sessions: Less time is spent warming up compared to full-body, since you are training muscles that work together (E.g., chest, triceps and shoulders)
- Can squeeze in more volume per session
- Higher average set quality than bro split – Each muscle group gets at least two days per week of training.

Cons:

- 6 days per week in the gym. This may be mentally and physically draining.
- May encourage junk volume

Please don't start overthinking your training splits. The best split for you is one that you can stay consistent with. **BE REALISTIC**. Don't do 5 days if you know you'll struggle to fit it in. Also note, that there are many ways to arrange 3,4 or 5-day splits. These are just common examples. As mentioned above, I suggest starting with a 3 or 4-day split (MAX 5), to begin with before going to 6-day per-week programs. This gives you time to get used to the gym. If you do wish to do 6 days per week training, only do this once you have been able to stay consistent with 3 - 5 days per week training for at least **4 months continuously**.

4.7 Do I need to warm up?

Warming up is essential for physically and mentally preparing yourself for the main workout. Your joints, muscles, and nervous system need to be primed for the main work. If done correctly, warm-ups should help improve your performance, as well as minimise the chance of injury. However, you don't need to overdo this. 5 to 10 mins at the start of a workout should be more than enough, depending on how you feel on the day.

In each workout, there will be **two stages** to your warm-up: General and specific warm-ups.

4.7.1 – Stage 1 - General Warm-up

The purpose of the **general** warm-up is to raise the overall core body temperature, increase general blood flow to the muscles and increase general flexibility. There are two parts to the general warm-up:

- 1) **Light cardio**: This should be 2 – 5 minutes of light cardiovascular activity. For example, the exercise bike, walking on a treadmill, the cross-trainer, or even performing star jumps. Common mistakes with this include:
 - Just “going through the motions”. You should be focused because the warm-up is a mental preparation as well as a physical one.
 - Overdoing it. People will overdo the cardio warm-up before the weights, and fatigue themselves. This will reduce the performance on the weight training. The warm-up cardio should **NOT** be fatiguing. If you want to perform strenuous cardio, this should be done **AFTER** the main weight training.
- 2) **Dynamic Stretching**: These are stretches that involve the movement of your joints through space. This helps improve flexibility and range of motion [10]. It doesn't need to be anything fancy. Some examples of dynamic stretching routines are given, which are based on the type of workout you may be doing on the day. Each movement is to be performed for **1 – 2 sets** of the prescribed number of reps.

Lower body workout	Upper body workout
Forward/Reverse leg swings x 12-15 per leg	Horizontal arm swings x 12 – 15
Side leg swings x 12-15 per leg	Arm rotations (backward) x 12 – 15
Hip rotations x 12-15 per	

leg	Arm rotations (forward) x 12 – 15
Heel flicks x 12 – 15 per leg	
Horizontal arm swings x 12 - 15	

To warm-up for a **full-body** workout, combine both dynamic stretching routines (only do 1 – 2 sets of horizontal arm swings in total). Links to video demos are given below.

Lower body Dynamic Stretching: https://youtu.be/lj_Pcxk3vH8

Upper body Dynamic Stretching: <https://youtube.com/shorts/EE6kbHlar-I>

The full general warm-up should take a total of 5 – 10 minutes.

4.7.2 – Stage 2 - Specific Warm-up

The **specific warm-up** primes you to perform the specific lift. **THIS IS ESSENTIAL.** It ensures that the **specific** muscles and joints for the movement will be warmed up before the working sets. Additionally, it is an opportunity to practice the form for the movement, and re-ingrain safe movement patterns. It will also help your performance. How do you do a **specific** warm-up? Simply perform **“Warm-up sets”**.

- 1) **Choose a very light weight that is not challenging.** Perform anywhere from 10 – 20 reps (depending on the weight and exercise).
- 2) **Increase the weight slightly.** Increase the weight slightly and perform a second set of 5 – 12 reps. Again, the weight should feel very light for this rep range. I must re-iterate this is very movement dependent.

Should we do a specific warm-up for every exercise in the workout?

Most of the time, your first movement should be a compound movement, so this protocol is essential for your first movement of the day. A minimum of 2-warm up sets should be performed for exercises using muscles that have not yet been used that day (Though as you get stronger, more warm-up sets will be needed). For example, in a lower body workout, you may do front squats (quad-dominant) followed by Romanian deadlifts (Hamstring/Glute dominant) so both exercises would require warm-up sets to be performed. However, later in the workout, you may perform “smaller” movements such as lunges and leg curls. The quadriceps and hamstrings would already be sufficiently warm from the previous exercises, therefore additional warm-up sets for these exercises wouldn’t be necessary. Another example would be performing lat pull-downs after performing dumbbell rows earlier in the workout.

To summarise, a warm-up consists of two parts: A **general** warm-up to raise core body

temperature and flexibility and a **specific** warm-up to practice the movement before performing the main working sets.

4.8 Designing your program – Customisable Templates

On the next few pages, there are some customisable templates that you can use to design your own workout program. It suggests how to structure **types** of exercises, along with appropriate progression schemes. Once you choose an exercise and rep range, try to keep them the same for a minimum of 12 weeks (Ideally longer) to learn the form, and track progress. **The exercise library in chapter 5 provides a list of exercises to choose from, along with tutorials. Choose suitable exercises from chapter 5, structuring them as shown in the customisable templates in the following pages.** I highly suggest creating a diary (e.g., Use the notes app on phone, or physical notebook) to **record your performance and set weekly targets.** Use the first few weeks to learn proper technique. It's fine to keep the weight the same, or use trial and error to find suitable weights for the first few weeks.

Alternative - Sample Program

Alternatively, there is a sample program which is pre-designed for you. It is designed as described in the instructions in 4.8.1. All you have to do is run the program, **NOTE DOWN YOUR REPS (and weight etc.)**, strive for gradual improvement and enjoy the gains.

After 12 weeks, what next?

Keep going. Training is a lifelong commitment. Not a 90-day challenge. After 12 weeks, you can switch things up if you want something fresh. Examples include:

- Changing the progression scheme for a certain exercise. For example, if you stall on double progression for 3 weeks in a row for a specific exercise, (i.e., you can't add any weight or reps for 3 weeks), you can switch to dynamic double progression.
- Training in a different rep range to train a different threshold. For example, moving from 5 – 8 to 4 – 6 reps on barbell back squats to train slightly closer to the maximal strength threshold.
- Switch a movement out for another. If you do this, it should be like for like (e.g., Bench press to close grip bench press). Don't swap a squat for a bicep curl.

I recommend keeping the exercises the same and progressing on them for as long as possible before adding changes. Only change one thing at a time as needed. This is so you can easily gauge your progress and learn the movements properly. You can also change the split if you wish. The total weekly volume is the same for all splits.

3-day Full Body Template

Workout 1

1. Squat 3 sets, double progression
2. Vertical Push, 3 sets, double progression
3. Vertical Pull 3 sets, double progression
4. Hip Hinge, 3 sets, double progression
5. Horizontal Push (Any Machine or bodyweight), rep goal system or double progression
6. Arm Curl and Arm Extension Superset, 3 sets each, rep goal system
7. Side and Rear delt superset, 3 sets each, double progression for both
8. Ab exercise, 2 sets, double progression

Workout 2

1. Horizontal Push, 3 sets, double progression
2. Horizontal Pull, 3 sets, double progression
3. Lunge. 3 sets, double progression
4. Leg Curl 3 sets, rep goal system
5. Horizontal Pull (Any Machine or bodyweight) 3 sets, rep goal system
6. Any Calf raises, 4 sets, rep goal system
7. Side and Rear delt superset, 2 sets, double progression
8. Plank and Oblique Twist superset, double progression for both

Workout 3

1. Hip Hinge, 3 sets, double progression
2. Horizontal or Vertical Push. 3 sets, double progression
3. Horizontal Pull (Any Chest -Supported, machine-based or bodyweight), 3 sets, rep goal system
4. Vertical Pull, 3 sets, rep goal system
5. Lunge, 3 sets, double progression
6. Arm Curls and Arm extension Superset, 3 sets, rep goal system
7. Ab exercise, 2 sets, double progression

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5	Day 6	Day 7
Workout 1	Rest	Workout 2	Rest	Workout 3	Rest	Rest

4-day Lower Body/Upper Body Template

Lower Body 1

1. Squat, 3 sets, double progression
2. Hip Hinge 3 sets, double progression
3. Lunges 3 sets, double progression
4. Vertical Pull 3 sets, double progression
5. Any Calf raises, 4 sets, rep goal system
6. Ab exercise, 2 sets, double progression

Lower Body 2

1. Hip Hinge, 3 sets, double progression
2. Lunges, 3 sets, double progression
3. Leg Curl, 3 sets, rep goal system
4. Ab exercise, 2 sets, double progression
5. Plank and Oblique Twist superset, 2 sets each, double progression

Upper Body 1

1. Horizontal Push, 3 sets, double progression
2. Horizontal Pull, sets, double progression
3. Horizontal or Vertical Push, 3 sets, double progression
4. Horizontal Pull (Any Machine, chest-supported or bodyweight) 3 sets, double progression
5. Arm Curl and Extension Superset, 3 sets, rep goal system
6. Side and Rear delt superset, 3 sets each, double progression for both

Upper Body 2

1. Vertical Push, 3 sets, double progression
2. Vertical Pull, 3 sets, double progression
3. Horizontal Push (Any Machine or bodyweight), 3 sets, rep goal system
4. Horizontal Pull (Any Chest - Supported or machine-based), 3 sets, double progression
5. Arm Curl and Arm Extension Superset, 3 sets, rep goal system
6. Side and Rear delt superset 2 sets, double progression for both

Suggested 4-day Schedule

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5	Day 6	Day 7
Lower Body 1	Upper Body 1	Rest	Lower Body 2	Upper Body 2	Rest	Rest

(5-day template on the next page)

5-day Lower Body/Upper Body/Leg/Push/Pull Template

Lower Body 1

1. Squat 3 sets, double progression
2. Hip Hinge, 3 sets, double progression
3. Lunges, 3 sets, double progression
4. Vertical Pull 3 sets, double progression
5. Any Calf raises, 4 sets, double progression
6. Ab exercise, 2 sets, double progression

Upper Body 1

1. Horizontal Push, 3 sets, double progression
2. Horizontal Pull, sets, double progression
3. Horizontal or Vertical Push, 3 sets, double progression
4. Horizontal Pull (Any Machine, chest-supported or bodyweight) 3 sets, double progression
5. Arm Curl and Extension Superset, 3 sets, rep goal system
6. Side and Rear delt superset, 3 sets each, double progression for both

Legs

1. Hip Hinge 3 sets, double progression
2. Lunges 3 sets, double progression
3. Leg Curl 3 sets, double progression or rep goal system
4. Ab exercise 2 sets, double progression
5. Plank and Oblique Twist superset 2 sets, double progression for both

Push

1. Vertical Push, 3 sets, double progression
2. Horizontal Push (Any Machine or bodyweight), 3 sets, Rep goal system or double progression
3. Arm Extension, 3 sets, rep goal system
4. Side delt exercise, 3 sets, double progression

Pull

- 1. Vertical Pull, 3 sets, double progression**
- 2. Horizontal Pull (Any Chest -Supported or machine-based) 3 sets, double progression**
- 3. Arm Curl 3 sets, rep goal system**
- 4. Rear delt Exercise 3 sets, double progression**

Suggested 5-day Schedule

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5	Day 6	Day 7
Lower Body 1	Upper Body	Rest	Lower Body 2	Push	Pull	Rest

4.9 How to use the customisable templates:

- 1) Choose which split suits you.
- 2) Check the type of exercise for each workout. For example, it may say “Horizontal push.” It will also show you the progression scheme to use.
- 3) Check the relevant section in the exercise library. For example, horizontal pushes are in section 4.
- 4) Choose your preferred exercise. For example, for horizontal pushes, you may wish to do either a barbell or a dumbbell bench press. Choose your preferred rep range. Do this for all exercises you see in the templates above to craft your routine. The table below tells you where to find the selection of different types of exercises in the library.

Exercise Library Section	Exercise Type	Page references
1	Squats	59 - 65
2	Lunges	65 - 70
3	Hip Hinges	71 - 76
4	Horizontal Pushes	77 - 88
5	Horizontal Pulls	89 - 101
6	Vertical Pushes	102 - 105
7	Vertical Pulls	106 - 118
8	Chest flys	119 - 123
9	Arm Extensions	124 - 128
10	Arm Curls	129 - 135
11	Side delt Exercises	136 - 138
12	Rear delt Exercises	139 - 143
13	Calf raises	143 - 146
14	Leg curls	147 - 148
15	Leg extensions	149
16	Core	150 - 159

Sample program

Alternatively, if you want a routine to jump straight into, there are some sample routines on the next few pages. This includes a 3, 4, or 5-day split. Pick one and stick with it for a minimum of 12 weeks before changing things up.

3-day Split: Full Body

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5	Day 6	Day 7
Workout 1	Rest	Workout 2	Rest	Workout 3	Rest	Rest

Full-body Workout 1

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Tutorial Reference
Barbell Back Squats	3 x 5 – 8	Double Progression	120 – 180	1a (pg. 59)
Barbell Military Press	3 x 5 – 8	Double Progression	120 – 180	6a (pg. 102)
Lat pull-downs (neutral grip or underhand)	3 x 8 -12	Double Progression	90-120	Neutral grip: 7f (pg. 114) OR 7g (pg. 115), OR Underhand: 7j (pg. 118)
Dumbbell Romanian Deadlifts	3 x 8 - 12	Double Progression	90 -120	3c (pg. 76)
(Weighted) Deficit Push Ups	3 x AMRAP (Total rep goal: 40)	Rep goal System	90 - 120	4l (pg. 88)
Superset: B1: Standing Dumbbell Curls B2: Lying Dumbbell Extensions	Curls and Extensions: 3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal: 40) For both	Rep goal system (For both)	60 -90 seconds between each superset	Standing Dumbbell curls: 10a (pg. 129) Lying Dumbbell Extensions: 9b (pg. 125)
Superset: A1: Skiers A2: Seated Lateral Raises	3 x 15 – 20	Double Progressions	30-60 seconds between each superset	Skiers: 12b (pg. 140) Seated Lateral Raises: 11a (pg. 136 – 137)
Hanging Knee Raises	2 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	90 – 120	16e (pg. 154)

Full-body Workout 2

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Tutorial Reference
Flat Barbell Bench Press	3 x 5 - 8	Double Progression	120 – 180	4a (pg. 77)
Single Arm Dumbbell Rows	3 x 8 - 12	Double Progression	90 -120 (after both sides are completed)	5a (pg. 89)
Walking Lunges	3 x 8 – 12 per leg	Double Progression	120	2e (pg. 70)
Lying Leg curls	3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal: 40)	Rep Goal System	90	14a (pg. 147)
Chest-Supported Dumbbell Row	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	90-120	5b (pg. 90) or 5c (pg. 91)
Smith Machine Calf Raises	4 x AMRAP (Total Rep goal: 70)	Calf Raises: Rep Goal System	60-90	13a (pg. 143)
Superset A1: Rope Face pulls A2: Standing Dumbbell Lateral Raises	3 x 15 – 20 (For both)	Double Progression (for both)	30-60 seconds between each superset	Face pulls: 12a (pg. 139) Standing Dumbbell Lateral raises: 11a (pg. 136)
Superset A1: (Weighted) Plank A2: Russian Oblique Twists	(Weighted) Plank: 2 x 30 – 60 seconds Oblique Twists: 2 x 15 – 30 per side	Double progression (for both)	30 - 60 seconds between each superset	Plank: 16j (pg. 158) Oblique Twists: 16k (pg. 159)

Full-body Workout 3

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Tutorial Reference
Barbell Deadlifts (Conventional)	3 x 4 – 6	Double Progression	120 – 240	3a (pg. 71)
Incline Dumbbell Bench Press	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	4f (pg. 82)
Chest-Supported Dumbbell Row	3 x 8 - 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	5b (pg. 90) or 5c (pg. 91)
Reverse Lunges	12 – 15 per leg	Double Progression	120	2c (pg. 66)
Lat pull-downs (Standard overhand)	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	7h (pg. 116)
Superset: A1: EZ-bar bicep curls A2: Lying EZ-bar Tricep Extensions	3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal 30)	Rep Goal System (for both)	30 – 60 seconds between each superset	EZ-bar curls: 10f (pg. 135) Lying EZ-bar extensions: 9a (pg. 124)
Cable Crunches	2 x 10 – 20 reps	Double progression	90-120	16c (pg. 152)

4-day Split: Lower/Upper Body

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5	Day 6	Day 7
Lower Body 1	Upper Body 1	Rest	Lower Body 2	Upper Body 2	Rest	Rest

Lower body 1

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Tutorial reference
Barbell Back Squats	3 x 5 – 8	Double Progression	120 – 180	1a (pg. 59)
Dumbbell Romanian Deadlifts	3 x 8 - 12	Double Progression	90 -120	3c (pg. 76)
Walking Lunges	3 x 8 – 12 per leg	Double Progression	120	2e (pg. 70)
Lat pull-downs (neutral grip or underhand)	3 x 8 -12	Double Progression	90-120	Neutral grip: 7f (pg. 114) OR 7g (pg. 115), OR Underhand: 7i (pg. 118)
Smith Machine Calf Raises	4 x AMRAP (Total Rep goal: 70)	Calf Raises: Rep Goal System	60-90	13a (pg. 143)
Hanging Knee Raises	2 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	90 – 120	16e (pg. 154)

Upper body 1

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Tutorial reference
Flat Barbell Bench Press	3 x 5 - 8	Double Progression	120 – 180	4a (pg. 77)
Single Arm Dumbbell Rows	3 x 8 - 12	Double Progression	90 -120 (after both sides are completed)	5a (pg. 89)
Incline Dumbbell Bench Press	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	4f (pg. 82)
Chest-Supported Dumbbell Row	3 x 8 - 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	5b (pg. 90) or 5c (pg. 91)
Superset: B1: Standing Dumbbell Curls B2: Lying Dumbbell Extensions	Curls and Extensions: 3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal: 40) For both	Rep goal system (For both)	60 -90 seconds between each superset	Standing Dumbbell curls: 10a (pg. 129) Lying Dumbbell Extensions: 9b (pg. 125)
Superset: A1: Skiers A2: Seated Lateral Raises	3 x 15 – 20	Double Progressions	30-60 seconds between each superset	Skiers: 12b (pg. 140) Seated Lateral Raises: 11a (pg. 136 – 137)

Lower body 2

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Library Reference
Barbell Deadlifts	3 x 4 – 6	Double Progression	120 - 240	<u>3a (pg. 71)</u>
Reverse Lunges	12 – 15 per leg	Double Progression	120	<u>2c (pg. 66)</u>
Lying Leg curls	3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal: 40)	Rep Goal System	90	<u>14a (pg. 147)</u>
Cable Crunches	2 x 10 – 20 reps	Double progression	90-120	<u>16c (pg. 152)</u>
Superset A1: (Weighted) Plank A2: Russian Oblique Twists	(Weighted) Plank: 2 x 30 – 60 seconds Oblique Twists: 2 x 15 – 30 per side	Double progression (for both)	30 - 60 seconds between each superset	<u>Plank: 16j (pg. 158)</u> <u>Oblique Twists: 16k (pg. 159)</u>

Upper body 2

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Tutorial Reference
Barbell Military Press	3 x 5 - 8	Double Progression	120 – 180	6a (pg. 102)
Lat pull-downs (Standard overhand)	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	7h (pg. 116)
(Weighted) Deficit Push Ups	3 x AMRAP (Total rep goal: 40)	Rep goal System	90 - 120	4l (pg. 88)
Chest-Supported Dumbbell Row	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	90-120	5b (pg. 90) or 5c (pg. 91)
Superset A1: Rope Face pulls A2: Standing Dumbbell Lateral Raises	3 x 15 – 20 (For both)	Double Progression (for both)	30-60 seconds between each superset	Face pulls: 12a (pg. 139) Standing Dumbbell Lateral raises: 11a (pg. 136)
Superset: A1: EZ-bar bicep curls A2: Lying EZ-bar Tricep Extensions	3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal 30)	Rep Goal System (for both)	30 – 60 seconds between each superset	EZ-bar curls: 10f (pg. 135) Lying EZ-bar extensions: 9a (pg. 124)

5-day Split: Lower/Upper /Legs/Push/ Pull

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5	Day 6	Day 7
Lower Body 1	Upper Body 1	Rest	Lower Body 2	Push	Pull	Rest

Lower body 1

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Tutorial reference
Barbell Back Squats	3 x 5 – 8	Double Progression	120 – 180	1a (pg. 59)
Dumbbell Romanian Deadlifts	3 x 8 - 12	Double Progression	90 -120	3c (pg. 76)
Walking Lunges	3 x 8 – 12 per leg	Double Progression	120	2e (pg. 70)
Lat pull-downs (neutral grip or underhand)	3 x 8 -12	Double Progression	90-120	Neutral grip: 7f (pg. 114) OR 7g (pg. 115), OR Underhand: 7j (pg. 118)
Smith Machine Calf Raises	4 x AMRAP (Total Rep goal: 70)	Calf Raises: Rep Goal System	60-90	13a (pg. 143)
Hanging Knee Raises	2 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	90 – 120	16e (pg. 154)

Upper body

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Library Reference
Flat Barbell Bench Press	3 x 5 - 8	Double Progression	120 – 180	4a (pg. 77)
Single Arm Dumbbell Rows	3 x 8 - 12	Double Progression	90 -120 (after both sides are completed)	5a (pg. 89)
Incline Dumbbell Bench Press	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	4f (pg. 82)
Chest-Supported Dumbbell Row	3 x 8 - 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	5b (pg. 90) or 5c (pg. 91)
Superset: B1: Standing Dumbbell Curls B2: Lying Dumbbell Extensions	Curls and Extensions: 3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal: 40) For both	Rep goal system (For both)	60 -90 seconds between each superset	Standing Dumbbell curls: 10a (pg. 129) Lying Dumbbell Extensions: 9b (pg. 125)
Superset: A1: Skiers A2: Seated Lateral Raises	3 x 15 – 20	Double Progressions	30-60 seconds between each superset	Skiers: 12b (pg. 140) Seated Lateral Raises: 11a (pg. 136-137)

Lower body 2

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Library Reference
Barbell Deadlifts	3 x 4 – 6	Double Progression	120 - 240	3a (pg. 71)
Reverse Lunges	12 – 15 per leg	Double Progression	120	2c (pg. 66)
Lying Leg curls	3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal: 40)	Rep Goal System	90	14a (pg. 147)
Cable Crunches	2 x 10 – 20 reps	Double progression	90-120	16c (pg. 152)
Superset A1: (Weighted) Plank A2: Russian Oblique Twists	(Weighted) Plank: 2 x 30 – 60 seconds Oblique Twists: 2 x 15 – 30 per side	Double progression (for both)	30 - 60 seconds between each superset	Plank: 16j (pg. 158) Oblique Twists: 16k (pg. 159)

Push

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Tutorial Reference
Barbell Military Press	3 x 5 - 8	Double Progression	120 – 180	6a (pg. 102)
Incline Dumbbell Bench Press	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	4f (pg. 82)
Lying EZ-bar Tricep Extensions	3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal 30)	Rep Goal System (for both)	90	Lying EZ-bar extensions: 9a (pg. 124)
Standing dumbbell Lateral Raises	3 x 15 - 20	Double Progression	60 - 90	Standing Dumbbell Lateral raises: 11a (pg. 136)

(SEE PULL SESSION ON NEXT PAGE)

Pull

Exercise	Working Sets x Reps	Progression Scheme	Suggested Rest period (Seconds)	Tutorial Reference
Lat pull-downs (Standard overhand)	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	120 - 180	7h (pg. 116)
Chest-Supported Dumbbell Row	3 x 8 – 12	Double Progression	90-120	5b (pg. 90) or 5c (pg. 91)
EZ-bar bicep curls	3 x AMRAP (Total Rep Goal 30)	Rep Goal System	60 - 90	10f (pg. 135)
Skiers	3 x 15 – 20	Double Progressions	30-60 seconds between each superset	12b (pg. 140)

(See tutorials in the exercise library, starting on the next page)

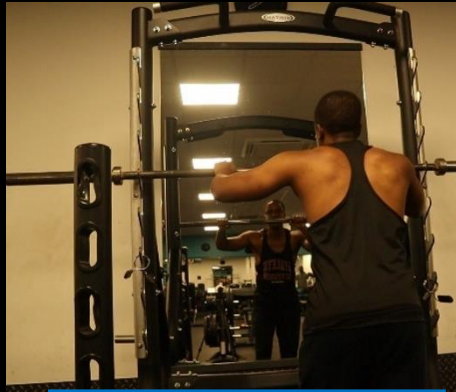
Chapter 5: Exercise Library

1) Squats

a) Barbell Back Squat

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=97>

Working Muscles: Quadriceps, Glutes, (Abs also act as stabilisers)



Step 1: Set the bar in the rack at around shoulder height. Grip it at shoulder-width or just outside of shoulder-width.



Step 2: While maintaining the grip width, squeeze your shoulder blades together. This should create a “shelf” for the bar. Rest the bar on your traps (just above the shoulders).



Step 3: Push the bar off the rack using your legs and take 2 small steps (per foot) back. Stand with your feet at around shoulder width and toes pointed out slightly. You may have to experiment with stance width and foot angle over time to find what is most comfortable for you. Take a deep breath and brace your core.



Step 4: Sit back and bend your knees until your thighs are at least parallel, or slightly below parallel with the ground, keeping the bar in line with the mid-foot. The bar path should be vertically straight, and your feet should maintain FULL CONTACT with the ground.



Step 5: Drive yourself up at the hips and the knees. “Open the knees” on the way up to ensure that they are in line with the toes. Breathe out at the top. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

*NB – You may wish to rest the bar on your rear delts (back of the shoulders), which will be slightly lower on your back. This is known as a **low bar squat**. Some may find this awkward, and some **may** find this more comfortable (e.g., taller individuals). It will depend on your limb lengths. Note that if you perform this “low bar” variant, the glutes will be emphasised slightly more, but the quads will still get a sufficient stimulus. Additionally, there will naturally be a little more forwards lean. Don’t overthink this. Choose which bar position is most comfortable for you and stick with it. As you gain more experience, you may wish to mix in both. See below:



“Low bar” setup.



Slight extra forward lean



If you have trouble reaching sufficient depth without your heels leaving the ground, you may have limited ankle mobility. Elevating your heels using plates may help you get around this problem. This is a good temporary fix, but in the long term, it will be beneficial for you to work on improving your ankle mobility.

Suggested rep range(s): 4 – 6, 5 – 8

Alternatives: Barbell Front Squat, Goblet Squat, Leg Press

b) Barbell Front Squat (*NB – Requires sufficient wrist mobility)

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=253>

Working Muscle(s): Quadriceps, Glutes (Abs and upper back also act as stabilisers)



Step 1: Set the bar in the rack at around shoulder height. Rest the bar just behind your front delts (around the collarbone). Additionally, hold it with 2 – 3 fingers (index + middle fingers, or index + middle + ring fingers). It will make light contact with your neck. Keep your chest up, and elbows up and forward. Your upper arms should be parallel to the ground.

Step 2: While maintaining upper body position, push the bar off the rack using your legs and take 2 small steps (per foot) back. Stand with your feet at around shoulder width with toes pointed out slightly. You may have to experiment with stance width and foot angle over time to find what is most comfortable for you. Take a deep breath and brace your core.



Step 3: Bend your knees and sit back slightly until your thighs are slightly below parallel with the ground, keeping the bar in line with the mid-foot. The bar path should be vertically straight, and your feet should maintain **FULL CONTACT** with the ground. Again, maintain the upper body position.



Step 4: Drive yourself up at the hips and the knees. “Open the knees” on the way up to ensure that they are in line with the toes. Breathe out. Repeat for the desired number of reps.



***NB -** If you have trouble reaching sufficient depth without your heels leaving the ground, you may have limited ankle mobility. Elevating your heels using plates may help you get around this problem. This is a good temporary fix, but in the long term, it will be beneficial for you to work on improving your ankle mobility.



***NB –** If your wrist mobility does not allow you use the grip above, you can adopt a cross armed grip, holding the bar just behind the front delts. Note that your shoulders may start to fatigue more quickly with this variation.

Suggested rep range(s): 4 – 6, 5 – 8

Alternatives: Barbell Back Squat, Goblet Squats, Leg Press

c) Goblet Squats

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=348>

Working Muscle Group(s): Quadriceps, Glutes



Step 1: Stand with your feet shoulder-width apart and your toes pointing slightly outwards. Keep your chest up. Hold a dumbbell by your chest, brace your core and take a deep breath.



Step 2: Sit back and bend your knees until your thighs are at least parallel, or slightly below parallel with the ground. The dumbbell should move vertically straight, and your feet should maintain FULL CONTACT with the ground. Briefly pause at the bottom, maintaining tightness.



Step 3: Drive yourself up at the hips and the knees. "Open the knees" on the way up to ensure that they are in line with the toes. Breathe out. Repeat for the desired number of reps.



***NB -** If you have trouble reaching sufficient depth without your heels leaving the ground, you may have limited ankle mobility. Elevating your heels using plates may help you get around this problem. This is a good temporary fix, but in the long term, it will be beneficial for you to work on improving your ankle mobility.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 - 12

Alternatives: Barbell Back Squat, Barbell Front Squat, Leg Press

d) Leg press

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/2G95MBZQkzo>

Muscles worked: Quads, Glutes



Step 1: Set yourself up so that you grip the handles firmly, and your feet can make full contact with the platform. The legs should be slightly bent, but near full extension. The feet should be around shoulder-width or slightly wider. Choose a stance height that feels comfortable. Your feet should maintain full contact with the platform throughout the set.



Step 2: Push the platform up and turn the handles to remove the supports. Maintain grip of the handles throughout the set. Your legs should be near full extension, but not fully locked out. This is the starting position.



Step 3: Lower the platform as far as you can. Your knees should form a 90-degree angle (or less).



Step 4: Push back up until your legs are near full extension again. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 - 12

Alternatives: Barbell Back Squat, Barbell Front Squat, Goblet Squats

2) Lunges

a) Forward lunges

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=415>

Muscles worked: Quads, Glutes (Abs and obliques also act as stabilisers)



Step 1: Stand holding a dumbbell in each hand with your feet at around shoulder width.



Step 2: Stride one leg forward and bend both legs until your front thigh is at least parallel or slightly below parallel with the ground. Your front knee should be in line with the toes. If you have healthy knees, they can go over the toes slightly for extra quad stimulation. Your rear knee should be close to the ground. Keep your core tight and maintain a neutral spine.



Step 3: Push off the FRONT LEG back to the starting position. Repeat with the other leg. Repeat for the desired number of reps per leg.

Regression: You can perform this exercise without dumbbells to begin with if you wish.

NB – You can do one leg at a time, or you can alternate legs between each leg.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 per leg, 12 – 15 per leg

Alternatives: Reverse Lunges, Bulgarian split squats, Step ups, Walking Lunges

b) Reverse Lunges

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=459>

Muscles worked: Quads, Glutes (Abs and obliques also act as stabilisers)



Step 1: Stand holding a dumbbell in each hand with your feet at around shoulder width.



Step 2: Stride one leg backwards and bend both legs until your front thigh is at least parallel or slightly below parallel with the ground. Your front knee should be in line with the toes. Your rear knee should be close to the ground. Keep your core tight and maintain a neutral spine.



Step 3: Push off the **FRONT LEG** back to the starting position. Repeat with the other leg. Repeat for the desired number of reps per leg.

Regression: You can perform this exercise without dumbbells to begin with if you wish.

NB – You can do one leg at a time, or you can alternate legs between each leg.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 per leg, 12 – 15 per leg

Alternatives: Forward Lunges, Bulgarian split squats, Step ups, Walking Lunges

c) Step ups

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=471>

Muscles worked: Quads, Glutes (Abs and obliques also act as stabilisers)



Step 1: Set up a platform so that you can raise one leg with your foot fully planted on it. Hold a dumbbell on each side. Your front thigh should be parallel or slightly below parallel with the ground. The knee should be in line with the toes. If you have healthy knees, your knees can go slightly over the toes for extra quad stimulation.

Step 2: Push off your **FRONT LEG** until you are standing fully upright. You can use the other leg to aid in balancing, by lightly touching it at the top of the platform.

Step 3: Lower yourself under control back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps for each leg.

NB – You can do one leg at a time, or you can alternate legs between each rep.

Regression: You can perform this exercise without dumbbells to begin with if you wish.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 per leg, 12 – 15 per leg

Alternatives: Forward Lunges, Bulgarian split squats, Reverse Lunges, Walking Lunges

d) Bulgarian Split Squats

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=498>

Muscles worked: Quads, Glutes (Abs and obliques also act as stabilisers)



Step 1: Set a platform up that is around knee height. Stand with your back to it and your legs making light contact with it. Hold a dumbbell in each hand.



Step 2: Take a stride with one leg forward, keeping the rear leg back.



Step 3: Place your rear foot firmly on the surface. Keep your core tight. This is your starting position.



Step 4: Lower yourself under control until your thigh is roughly parallel with the ground.



Step 5: Push yourself back up to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps, then switch to the other leg and repeat.

Regression: You can perform this exercise without dumbbells to begin with if you wish.



You can perform this while resting your front heel on a plate. This will help achieve more depth if you have limited ankle mobility. However, in the long term, improving ankle mobility may be something for you to prioritise.



Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 per leg, 12 – 15 per leg

Alternatives: Forward Lunges, Step ups, Reverse Lunges, Walking Lunges

e) Walking Lunges

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Y3T8Tz8J9RE>

Muscles worked: Quads, Glutes (Abs and obliques also act as stabilisers)



Step 1: Stand holding a dumbbell in each hand with your feet at around shoulder width.



Step 2: Stride one leg forward and bend both legs until your front thigh is at least parallel or slightly below parallel with the ground. Your front knee should be in line with the toes. If you have healthy knees, they can go over the toes slightly for extra quad stimulation. Your rear knee should be close to the ground. Keep your core tight and maintain a neutral spine.



Step 3: Use your front leg to push yourself up and bring your rear leg forward. Repeat this with the other leg. Perform this, moving up and down a path until you've completed the desired number of reps for each leg.

Regression: You can perform this exercise without dumbbells to begin with if you wish.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 per leg, 12 – 15 per leg

Alternatives: Forward Lunges, Bulgarian split squats, Reverse Lunges, Step ups

3) Hip Hinges

a) Barbell Deadlift (Conventional)

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=548>

Working Muscles: Glutes, Hamstrings, Back (Spinal Erectors), Forearms



Step 1: Stand at the centre of the bar. Align the barbell with the middle of your feet (Ensure you select plates that allow the bar to be around mid-shin height).



Step 2: Stand at around a shoulder-width stance and your feet pointing slightly outward. As you gain experience, you can experiment with foot positioning to find the most comfortable position for you. This is a starting point.



Step 3: Move your hips back while keeping your chest up, and maintain your knees in a fixed position (slight bend). Your torso will lean forward while keeping a neutral spine. Allow this until you feel a full stretch in your hamstrings.

(SEE NEXT PAGE FOR THE NEXT STEPS)



Step 3: Maintaining a neutral spine, bend the legs until the shin touches the bar. Grip the bar just outside your legs. Pull your shoulders back. Brace your core and take a deep breath. This is your starting position.



Step 4: Drive with your legs to lift the bar up (imagine pushing the floor away from you) and bring your hips to the bar. Breathe out at the top. Keep your arms as straight as possible (but not locked out).



Step 5: Lower the bar under control. Return to the starting position. Do not bounce the bar back up. Reset at the bottom, and repeat for the desired number of reps.

(SEE MORE INFORMATION ON THE NEXT PAGE)

*NB – As you get stronger over time, you may wish to use a “mixed grip” to ease gripping the bar. This involves gripping the bar with one hand overhand and the other hand underhand. Make sure to keep your arms as straight as possible (but not locked out). Additionally, alternate the grip (i.e., over/underhand) for each hand weekly to avoid imbalances.



Suggested rep range(s): 4 – 6, 5 – 8

Alternatives: Barbell Romanian Deadlifts, Dumbbell Romanian Deadlift

(SEE ROMANIAN DEADLIFTS OM THE NEXT PAGE)

b) Barbell Romanian Deadlift

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=621>

Working Muscles: Glutes, Hamstrings, Back (Spinal Erectors), Forearms



Step 1: Stand at the centre of the bar. Align the barbell with the middle of your feet (Ensure you select plates that allow the bar to be around mid-shin height).



Step 2: Stand at around a shoulder-width stance and your feet pointing slightly outward. As you gain experience, you can experiment with foot positioning to find the most comfortable position for you. This is a starting point.



Step 3: Move your hips back while keeping your chest up, and maintain your knees in a fixed position (slight bend). Your torso will lean forward while keeping a neutral spine. Allow this until you feel a full stretch in your hamstrings.



Step 4: Maintaining a neutral spine, bend the legs until the shin touches the bar. Grip the bar just outside your legs. Pull your shoulders back. Brace your core and take a deep breath.



Step 5: Drive with your legs to lift the bar up (imagine pushing the floor away from you) and bringing your hips to the bar. Breathe out at the top. Keep your arms as straight as possible (but not locked out). This is the starting position.



Step 6: Shift your hips while keeping your chest up, shoulders back and legs straightened with a very slight bend (maintaining a neutral spine). This will cause your torso to lean forward. Do this until you feel a full stretch in the hamstrings. The bar should be around shin-height. Keep your arms straightened.



Step 7: Use your hamstrings and glutes to drive your hips towards the bar. This should raise your torso and get you back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps. The bar path should be straight up and down.

***NB – Steps 1 to 5 are the same as the conventional deadlift. This is the setup for the Romanian deadlift.**

***NB – As you get stronger over time, you may wish to use a “mixed grip” to ease gripping the bar. This which involves gripping the bar with one hand overhand and the other hand underhand. Make sure to keep your arms as straight as possible (but not locked out). Additionally, alternate the grip (i.e., over/underhand) for each hand weekly to avoid imbalances.**



Suggested rep range(s): 5 – 8, 6 – 10 8 – 12

Alternatives: Barbell Deadlifts (Conventional), Dumbbell Romanian Deadlifts

c) Dumbbell Romanian Deadlifts

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=672>

Muscles worked: Glutes, Hamstrings, Back (Spinal Erectors), Forearms



Step 1: Stand with two dumbbells, holding them with a pronated grip by your legs. Stand with feet around shoulder-width apart.



Step 2: Shift your hips back while keeping your chest up, shoulders back and legs straightened with a very slight bend (maintaining a neutral spine). This will cause your torso to lean forward. Do this until you feel a full stretch in the hamstrings. The dumbbells should be around shin height. Keep your arms straightened.



Step 3: Use your hamstrings and glutes to drive your hips towards the dumbbells. This should raise your torso and get you back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 or 12 - 15

Alternatives: Barbell Romanian Deadlifts, Barbell Conventional Deadlift

4) Horizontal pushes

a) Flat Barbell Bench Press:

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=80>

Working Muscle groups: Chest, Triceps, Shoulders (Front Delts)



Step 1: Grip the bar just outside of shoulder-width. (Around a thumb's length wider than shoulder-width.)

The bar should rest between the thumb and index finger.



Step 2: Tuck the elbows (upper arm should make roughly a 45-degree angle with the torso), pinch the shoulder blades and firmly plant feet on the floor (A).

Push the bar off the supports. Re-squeeze the shoulder blades if you need to, and re-tuck elbows further if you can (B).



Step 3: Start with the bar directly over your face (roughly eye/nose/chin level) (A).

Lower the bar down and forward so that it touches the chest.

You can add a brief pause if you wish. The bar should move in a slight "arc" (B).



Step 4: Push the bar up and back to the starting position. Again, the bar should move in a slight "arc". Repeat for the desired number of reps.

*NB – when tucking elbows, imagine trying to stop someone from tickling your armpits.

Suggested rep range(s): 4 – 6, 5 – 8, 6 – 10

Alternatives: Flat Dumbbell Bench Press, Flat close grip barbell bench press, Flat neutral-grip dumbbell bench-press, Machine chest press, push ups

b) Flat Dumbbell Bench Press

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=177>

Working muscle-groups: Chest, Triceps, Shoulders (Front Delts)



Step 1: Starting with the dumbbells on your lap (A), use your legs to move the dumbbells towards your shoulders, while leaning into the bench (B).

Your feet should be firmly planted on the floor.



Step 2:
Hold the dumbbells around chest level at a slight angle, with palms facing slightly inwards. Pinch your shoulder blades.



Step 3: Push the dumbbells up and back to around nose/eye/chin level. The dumbbells should move in a slight "arc".



Step 4: Lower the dumbbells down to around chest level, and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 – 12

Alternatives: Flat Barbell Bench Press, Flat close grip barbell bench press, Flat neutral-grip dumbbell bench-press, Machine chest press, push ups

c) Flat Close-grip Barbell Bench Press

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=285>

Muscles worked: Triceps, Chest, Shoulder (Front delts). This variation emphasises the triceps and upper chest.



Step 1: Grip the bar at a shoulder-width.

The bar should rest between the thumb and index finger. Keep feet firmly planted on the floor.



Step 2: Squeeze the shoulder blades and tuck the elbows. Lift the bar off the supports.



(Same side photos as standard flat Barbell bench)

Step 3:

Re-squeeze the shoulder blades if required, and tuck elbows further (if possible) (A).

Lower the bar down and forward to around lower chest height (B). The bar should move in a slight “arc”.



Step 4: Push the bar up and back to the starting position. Again, the bar should move in a slight “arc”. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

*NB – when tucking elbows, imagine trying to stop someone from tickling your armpits.

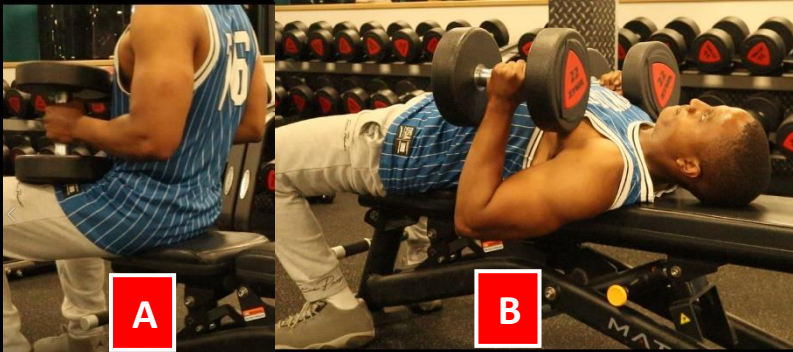
Suggested rep range(s): 5 - 8, 6 - 10, 8 -12

Alternatives: Flat neutral-grip dumbbell bench-press, Standard Flat barbell bench press, Flat Dumbbell Bench Press, Incline barbell bench press, Incline Dumbbell Bench Press, Machine chest press, push ups

d) Neutral-grip Dumbbell Bench Press

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=338>

Muscles worked: Triceps, Chest, Shoulders (Front delts). This variation emphasises the triceps and upper chest.



Step 1: Starting with the dumbbells on your lap (A), use your legs to move the dumbbells towards your shoulders, while leaning into the bench (B).

Your feet should be firmly planted on the floor.



Step 2:
Hold the dumbbells around chest level with a neutral grip and the palms facing fully inwards.

Squeeze shoulder blades and tuck your arms close to your torso.



Step 3: Push the dumbbells up and back to around nose/eye/chin level. The dumbbells should move in a slight “arc”.



Step 4: Lower the dumbbells down to around chest level, and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Alternatives: Flat close grip barbell bench press, Flat dumbbell bench-press, Flat Barbell Bench Press, Incline Dumbbell Bench press, Incline Barbell Bench Press, Machine chest press, push ups

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 -12

e) Incline Barbell Bench Press

General incline bench press info.: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=217>

Barbell incline bench press demo: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=235>



Step 1:
Set the bench at a 15 to 30-degree incline.



Step 2:
Grip the bar at a thumb's distance wider than shoulder width. Pinch the shoulder blades, tuck the elbows, and keep feet planted on the floor.



Step 3:
Lift the bar off the rack, re-pinch the shoulder blades (if needed), and tuck the elbows further (if possible). The bar should be around eye/nose/chin height.



Step 4:
Lower the bar down and forward so that it touches the chest. You can pause it for a brief second if you wish.



Step 5:
Push the bar up and back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 -12

*NB – when tucking elbows, imagine trying to stop someone from tickling your armpits.

Alternatives: Incline Dumbbell Bench Press, Flat close grip barbell bench press, Neutral-grip Dumbbell Bench Press, Machine chest press, Decline push ups

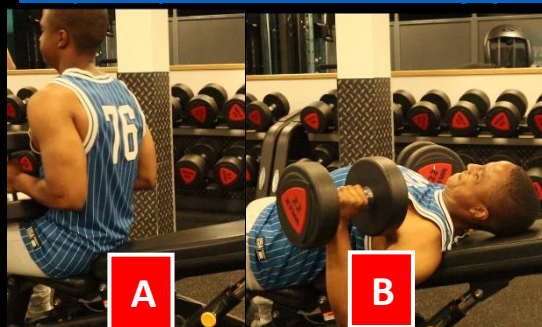
f) Incline Dumbbell Bench Press

Dumbbell Incline Bench Press demo: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=255>



Step 1:

Set the bench at a 15 to 30-degree incline.



Step 2: Starting with the dumbbells on your lap (A), use your legs to move the dumbbells towards your shoulders, while leaning into the bench (B).



Step 3:

Hold the dumbbells around chest level at a slight angle, with palms facing slightly inwards. Pinch your shoulder blades.



Step 4: Push the dumbbells up and back to around nose/eye /chin level. The dumbbells should move in a slight “arc”.



Step 5: Lower the dumbbells down to around chest level, and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Alternatives: Incline Barbell Bench Press, Flat close grip barbell bench press, Neutral-grip Dumbbell Bench Press, Machine chest press, Decline push ups

g) Dips (Chest-biased)

Video demo: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7mtp22iFPMA>

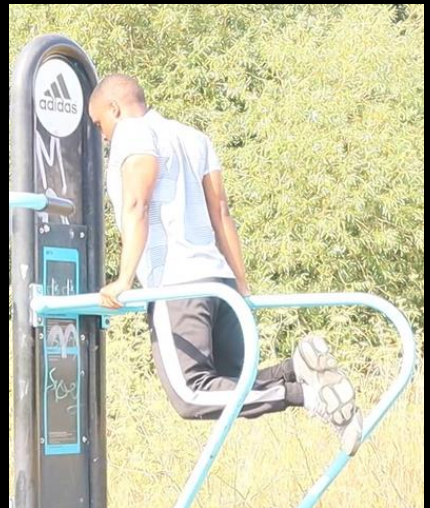
Working muscle-groups: Chest, Triceps, Shoulders (Front Delts)



Step 1: While suspending yourself, squeeze your shoulder blades and lean forward slightly for greater chest engagement. Your hands should be just outside shoulder-width.



Step 2: Lower yourself until your upper arm is parallel, or slightly below parallel with the ground.



Step 3: Push yourself back up, returning to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 4 – 6, 5 – 8, 6 – 10, 8 – 12 or 12 - 15.

Dips work well in a variety of rep ranges. The rep range will largely depend on how many dips you can do.

Alternatives: Deficit push-ups, Assisted Dips

Progressions: You can gradually transition into higher rep ranges. For example, from 4 – 6, to 6 – 10 reps.

If you can perform multiple sets of 15 dips with your body weight, consider adding weight. You can find reasonably priced pull-up/dip belts online (e.g., amazon, eBay). Alternatively, you can hold a dumbbell in between your legs, or even use a backpack.



Pull-up/dip belt

h) Standard Push up

Video Demo: <https://youtu.be/Hsk6zKOCchU?t=9>

Working muscle-groups: Chest, Triceps, Shoulders (Front Delts)



Step 1: Place your hands slightly outside of shoulder-width (arms extended), and straighten your legs behind you with the toes on the floor. **TUCK THE ELBOWS.** Keep your abs and glutes tight to help maintain a **neutral spine.**

Step 2: Lower yourself under control until your upper arms are parallel, or slightly below parallel with the ground.

Step 3: Push yourself up, returning to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12-15, 15 – 30. If you can't perform at least 15 regular push-ups with your bodyweight, consider easier variations (e.g., kneeling push-up, incline push-up).

Alternatives: Kneeling Push-ups, Incline Push-ups, Decline Push-ups, Deficit push-ups, Dips

Progression: If you can do multiple sets of 30 bodyweight push-ups with proper form, consider adding weight on your back (e.g., weight plate, backpack).

i) Kneeling push-ups

Video Demo: <https://youtu.be/Hsk6zKOCchU?t=89>

Working muscle-groups: Chest, Triceps, Shoulders (Front Delts)



Step 1: Place your hands slightly outside of shoulder-width (arms extended), and your knees on the ground. You can raise your feet, or place toes on the ground. **TUCK THE ELBOWS.** Keep your abs and glutes tight to help maintain a **neutral spine.**



Step 2: Lower yourself under control until your upper arms are parallel, or slightly below parallel with the ground.



Step 3: Push yourself up, returning to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 -15, 15 – 30.

Alternatives: Incline Push-ups, Standard Push-ups, Decline Push-ups, Deficit push-ups, Dips

Progression: If you can do multiple sets of 30 kneeling push-ups with proper form, consider progressing to paused reps with this variation (pausing for 0.5-1 seconds at the bottom) and building up to multiple sets of 30. If you wish, you can also progress to standard push-ups.

j) Incline Push-ups

Video Demo: <https://youtu.be/Hsk6zKOCchU?t=105>

Working muscle-groups: Chest, Triceps, Shoulders (Front Delts)



Step 1: Place your hands slightly outside of shoulder-width (arms extended) on a solid, elevated surface. Straighten your legs behind you with your toes on the ground. **TUCK THE ELBOWS.** Keep your abs and glutes tight to help maintain a neutral spine.

Step 2: Lower yourself under control until your chest is touching the surface. Your upper arms will be roughly in line with your torso.

Step 3: Push yourself up, returning to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 – 15, 15 – 30.

Alternatives: Incline Push-ups, Standard Push-ups, Decline Push-ups, Deficit push-ups, Dips

Progression: If you can do multiple sets of 30 decline push-ups with proper form, consider progressing to paused reps with this variation (pausing for 0.5-1 seconds at the bottom) and building up to multiple sets of 30. If you wish, you can also progress to standard push-ups.

k) Decline Push-ups

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Hsk6zKOCchU?t=132>

Working muscle-groups: Chest, Triceps, Shoulders (Front Delts)



Step 1: Place your hands slightly outside of shoulder-width (arms extended) on the ground. Straighten your legs behind you with your toes on an elevated surface.

TUCK THE ELBOWS.

Keep your abs and glutes tight to help maintain a neutral spine.

Step 2: Lower yourself under control until your upper arms are parallel, or slightly below parallel with the ground.

Step 3: Push yourself up, returning to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 – 15, 15 – 30.

Alternatives: Incline Push-ups, Standard Push-ups, Deficit push-ups, Kneeling Push-ups
Dips

Progression: If you can do multiple sets of 30 bodyweight decline push-ups with proper form, consider adding weight on your back. For this variation, a backpack would be the most practical way to do this.

(SEE NEXT PAGE FOR DEFICIT PUSH-UPS)

I) Deficit Push-ups

Video Demo: <https://youtu.be/Hsk6zKOCchU?t=167>

Working muscle-groups: Chest, Triceps, Shoulders (Front Delts)



Step 1: Place your hands on two slightly elevated surfaces which are slightly outside of shoulder-width. For example, two books, or two weight plates. Ensure there is a space that your chest can fit into. Straighten your legs behind you with your toes on the ground. Keep your abs and glutes tight to help maintain a neutral spine.

Step 2: Lower yourself under control until your upper arms are slightly below parallel with the ground. Your chest should be at roughly the same level, or slightly below the surfaces your hands are elevated on.

Step 3: Push yourself up, returning to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 – 15, 15 – 30.

Alternatives: Dips, Incline Push-ups, Standard Push-ups, Dips

Progression: If you can do multiple sets of 30 bodyweight deficit push-ups with proper form, consider adding weight on your back (e.g., backpack, weight plate).

5) Horizontal pulls

a) Standing one-arm Dumbbell Rows

Video Demo: <https://youtu.be/rLw3mIDrkNQ?t=274>

Working Muscle groups: Back (lat-emphasis), shoulders (rear delts), biceps, forearms



Step 1: Brace one hand against a sturdy surface. Your torso should be slightly above parallel with the ground. Hold the dumbbell in your other hand. One leg should be back (the leg on the side of your “working” arm and the other should be forward.



Step 2: Pull the dumbbell (“Pull with the elbow”) back to the hips until your upper arm is parallel or slightly past parallel with the torso. Keep your upper arm close to your torso.



Step 3: Lower the dumbbell under control until your arm is fully extended. Allow the dumbbell to drift forward slightly. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 - 12.

Alternatives: Seated V-bar cable rows, chest-supported dumbbell rows (neutral-grip)

b) Chest-supported Dumbbell Rows (Neutral-grip)

Video Demo: <https://youtu.be/rLw3mIDrkNQ?t=304>

Working Muscle groups: Back (lat-emphasis), shoulders (rear delts), biceps, forearms



Step 1: Set a bench at roughly a 45-degree incline. Lay prone against the bench whilst holding the dumbbells with your arms fully extended. Your palms should face each other.



Step 2: Pull the dumbbells ("Pull with the elbows") back to the hips until your upper arms are parallel or slightly past parallel with the torso. Keep your upper arms close to your torso.



Step 3: Lower the dumbbells under control until your arms are fully extended. Allow the dumbbells to drift forward slightly. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 – 12, 12 – 15.

Alternatives: Seated V-bar cable rows, Neutral grip Chest supported machine row, Single-arm dumbbell rows, underhand inverted rows

c) Chest Supported Dumbbell Rows (Wide)

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Q11FZLZsdBg?t=3>

Muscles worked: Back (Traps/Rhomboid Emphasis), Shoulders (Rear delts), Biceps, Forearms



Step 1: Set a bench at roughly a 45-degree incline. Lay prone against the bench whilst holding the dumbbells with your arms fully extended. Your palms should be facing behind you. Allow the shoulders to roll forward slightly.

Step 2: Pull the dumbbells “up and out”. Firmly squeeze your shoulder blades at the end of the rep.

Step 3: Lower the dumbbells under control back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 – 12, 12 – 15.

Alternatives: Seated Wide-grip cable rows, Wide grip Chest supported machine row, Wide grip inverted rows

d) Chest supported Machine Rows (Neutral Grip)

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Q11FZLZsdBg?t=80>

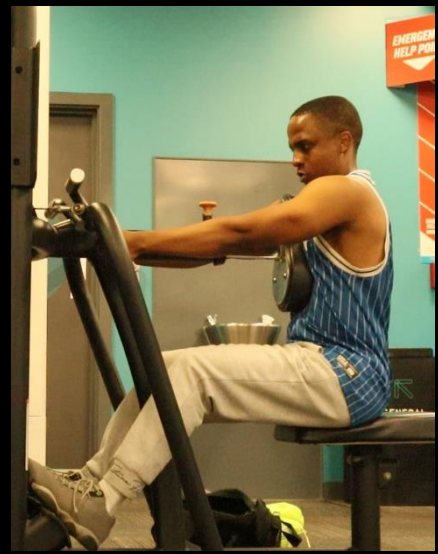
Muscles worked: Back (Lat Emphasis), Biceps, Shoulders (Rear delts)



Step 1: Set the machine up such that once you can grip the handles with your arms fully extended and your chest is resting fully against the pad. Grip the neutral handles (i.e., palms facing each other).



Step 2: Pull the handles ("Pull with the elbows") back to the hips until your upper arms are parallel or slightly past parallel with the torso. Keep your upper arms close to your torso.



Step 3: Allow the weight to drift forward under control, so that you drift back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12, 12 - 15

Alternatives: Seated V-bar cable rows, Neutral grip Chest supported dumbbell rows, Single-arm dumbbell rows, Underhand inverted rows

e) Chest supported Machine Rows (Wide Grip)

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Q11FZLZsdBg?t=89>

Muscles worked: Back (Trap/Rhomboid Emphasis), Biceps, Shoulders (Rear delts)



Step 1: Set the machine up such that once you can grip the handles with your arms fully extended your chest is resting fully against the pad and your shoulder blades are slightly forward. Grip the pronated handles (i.e., palms facing down) at around 1.5 – 2x shoulder-width.



Step 2: Pull the handles (“Pull with the elbows”) back until your shoulder blades are fully squeezed and until your elbows are behind the torso (as far as is comfortable for you).



Step 3: Allow the handles to drift forward under control, so that you drift back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12, 12 - 15

Alternatives: Seated Wide-grip cable rows, Wide grip inverted rows, Standard overhand inverted rows, Chest-supported wide grip dumbbell rows

f) V-bar cable rows

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Q11FZLZsdBg?t=65>

Muscles worked: Back (Lat-emphasis), Biceps, Forearms, Shoulders (Rear delts)



Step 1: Attach v-bar and set yourself up so that you can grip the bar with your arms fully extended. Grip the neutral handles (i.e., palms facing each other).



Step 2: Pull the bar ("Pull with the elbows") back to the hips until your upper arms are parallel or slightly past parallel with the torso. Keep your upper arms close to your torso.



Step 3: Allow the bar to drift forward under control, so that you drift back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12, 12 - 15

Alternatives: Neutral grip Chest supported machine row, Single-arm dumbbell rows, Underhand inverted rows, Neutral grip chest supported dumbbell rows

g) Wide-grip cable rows

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Q11FZLZsdBg?t=44>

Muscles worked: Back (Traps/Rhomboid emphasis), Biceps, Shoulders (Rear Delts)



Step 1: Attach a straight bar and set yourself up so that you can grip the bar with your arms fully extended, a neutral spine and shoulder blades slightly forward. Grip the bar with your palms facing down, at around 1.5 – 2x shoulder width. This is your starting position.



Step 2: Pull the bar (“Pull with the elbows”) to your lower ribs, trying to squeeze your shoulder blades together.



Step 3: Allow the bar to drift forward under control, so that you drift back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12, 12 - 15

Alternatives: Chest supported machine rows (Wide grip), Wide grip inverted rows, Chest supported Dumbbell rows (Wide grip)

h) Inverted rows (Standard overhand)

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/jeqrWlrYZwA>

Muscles worked: Back, Biceps, Forearms, Shoulders (Rear Delts)



Step 1:

Set the bar at around hip height. This should allow you to have your chest touching (or at least close to touching) the bar when you pull yourself up. Grip the bar with an overhand grip just outside of shoulder-width with your arms fully extended (not locked), with your upper chest in line with the bar. Fully extend your legs. Keep your core and glutes tight, keeping your hips up.



Step 2:

“Pull with your elbows” until your chest is touching or near touching the bar. Maintain a neutral spine, with a tight core and squeezed glutes. You should appear almost fully “straight” and diagonal from the side.



Step 3:

Lower yourself under control and return to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

***NB – EASIER VARIATION(s) – Bent-leg Inverted rows**



Bent legs can make the movement easier if the original version is too challenging. Over time, you can increase the length of the bend to gradually make the exercise more challenging.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12, 12 - 15

Alternatives: Standard overhand pull-ups, Chest-supported machine rows (any), Single-arm dumbbell rows, Underhand inverted rows, Wide-grip inverted rows, Neutral grip chest-supported dumbbell rows, Wide chest-supported dumbbell rows

i) Underhand Inverted Rows

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/jeqrWlrYZwA>

Muscles worked: Back (Lat-emphasis), Biceps, Forearms, Shoulders (Rear Delts)



Step 1:

Set the bar at around hip height. This should allow you to have your chest touching (or at least close to touching) the bar when you pull yourself up. Grip the bar with an underhand, shoulder-width grip with your arms fully extended (not locked). Your upper chest should be in line with the bar. Fully extend your legs. Keep your core and glutes tight, keeping your hips up.



Step 2:

“Pull with your elbows” until your chest is touching or near touching the bar. Maintain a neutral spine, tight core and squeezed glutes. You should appear almost fully “straight” and diagonal from the side.



Step 3:

Lower yourself under control and return to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

***NB – EASIER VARIATION(s) – Bent-leg Inverted rows**



Bent legs can make the movement easier if the original version is too challenging. Over time, you can increase the length of the bend to gradually make the exercise more challenging.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12, 12 - 15

Alternatives: Standard overhand inverted rows, Underhand Pull ups, Standard overhand pull-ups, Neutral-grip pull ups, Chest-supported machine rows (Neutral-grip), Single-arm dumbbell rows, Wide-grip inverted rows, Neutral grip chest-supported dumbbell rows

j) Wide-grip Inverted Rows

Video Demo: <https://youtu.be/jeqrWlrYZwA>

Muscles worked: Back (Trap/Rhomboid Emphasis), Biceps, Forearms, Shoulders (Rear Delts)



Step 1:

Set the bar at around hip height. This should allow you to have your chest touching (or at least close to) touching the bar when you pull yourself up. Grip the bar with an overhand grip. Your hands should be around 1.5 – 2 x shoulder-width. Your arms should be fully extended (not locked). Your upper chest should be in line with the bar. Fully extend your legs. Keep your core and glutes tight, keeping your hips up.



Step 2:

“Pull with your elbows” until your chest is touching or near touching the bar. Squeeze your shoulder blades at the top. Maintain a neutral spine, tight core and squeezed glutes. You should appear almost fully “straight” and diagonal from the side.



Step 3:

“Pull with your elbows” until your chest is touching or near touching the bar. Squeeze your shoulder blades at the top. Maintain a neutral spine, tight core and glutes. You should appear almost fully “straight” and diagonal from the side.



Bent legs can make the movement easier if the original version is too challenging. Over time, you can increase the length of the bend to gradually make the exercise more challenging.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12, 12 - 15

Alternatives: Standard overhand inverted rows, Wide-grip Pull ups, Chest-supported machine rows (Wide-grip), Wide chest-supported dumbbell rows

6) Vertical Pushes

a) Barbell Military Press

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/p8PG9XyOwyA?t=113>

Muscles worked: Shoulders (Front delts), Triceps



Step 1: Set up the rack at around armpit to shoulder height. The bar should be in line with around your upper chest area, just below the collarbone.

Step 2: Grip the bar at around shoulder width, standing with your feet also at shoulder width.



Step 3: Remove the bar from the rack (use your legs) and rest it on your upper chest before starting the set. Brace your core, squeeze your glutes, and take a deep breath. This is the starting position.

Step 4: Push the bar over your head, maintaining a neutral spine (avoid bending the back). Drive your head forward as you do this. Breathe out at the top. Keep the spine neutral and avoid using the legs for momentum.

Step 5: Lower the bar under control, returning to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 4 - 6, 5 - 8, 6 - 10

Alternatives: Seated Dumbbell Shoulder Press, Seated Dumbbell Arnold Press, Machine Shoulder Press

b) Seated Dumbbell Shoulder Press

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/p8PG9XyOwyA?t=212>

Muscles worked: Shoulder (Front delts), Triceps



Step 1:

Set the bench at a very steep incline (around 70 to 80 degrees, not fully vertical).

Sit in the seat, resting your back against the support. Rest the dumbbells on your legs.

Step 2:

Hold the dumbbells on your lap and use your legs to push them towards your shoulders. Hold them with your hands at a slight angle (palms facing slightly inwards).

Keep your feet firmly planted on the floor.

Step 3:

Push the dumbbells up and over your head.



Step 4:

Lower the dumbbells under control and return to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Alternatives: Barbell Military Press, Seated Dumbbell Arnold Press, Machine Shoulder Press

c) Seated Dumbbell Arnold Press

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/p8PG9XyOwyA?t=256>

Muscles worked: Shoulders (Front delts), Triceps



Step 1:

Set the bench at a very steep incline (around 70 to 80 degrees, not fully vertical).

Sit in the seat, resting your back against the support. Rest the dumbbells on your legs.



Step 2:

Use your legs to push the dumbbells towards your shoulders/collarbone chest.

Hold them with your palms facing towards you, around collarbone height.

Keep your feet firmly planted on the floor. **This is the starting position.**



Step 3:

Push the dumbbells up and over your head. Rotate your shoulders and arms when you do this so that at the top, your palms face away from you.



Step 4:

Lower the dumbbells under control and return to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 - 10, 8 – 12

Alternatives: Barbell Military Press, Seated Dumbbell Shoulder Press, Machine Shoulder Press

d) Machine shoulder press

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/cyqDWGzvoQI>

Muscles worked: Shoulders (Front delts), Triceps



Step 1:

Set the machine up so that the handles are just above the shoulders. Sit with your feet firmly planted on the floor, and firmly grip the handles.



Step 2:

Push up until your arms are fully extended



Step 3:

Lower the handles under control and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12

Alternatives: Barbell Military Press, Seated Dumbbell Arnold Press, Machine Shoulder Press

7) Vertical Pulls

a) Neutral-grip pull up (Back “width” biased)

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/rLw3mIDrkNQ?t=48>

Working muscle-groups: Back (Lat-emphasis), biceps, forearms



Step 1: Adopt a shoulder-width grip with palms facing each other. Start from a full DEAD-HANG.



Step 2: Pull yourself up until at least your chin is over the bar. Imagine “pulling with your elbows” and your hands as mere “hooks”.



Step 3: Lower yourself under control, returning to a dead-hang position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 4 – 6, 5 – 8, 6 – 10 or 8 – 12. Pull ups work well in a variety of rep ranges. The rep range will largely depend on how many pull-ups you are capable of.

Alternatives: Assisted neutral-grip pull-ups, V-bar or D-handle lat pull-downs, Underhand pull ups, Underhand lat pull-downs, Underhand Inverted rows. If you can’t perform at least 6 pull ups on your first set, consider using the alternatives.

Progressions: You can gradually transition into higher rep ranges. For example, from 4 – 6, to 6 – 10 reps.

If you can perform multiple sets of 12 pull ups with your body weight, consider adding weight. You can find reasonably priced pull-up/dip belts online (e.g., amazon, eBay). Alternatively, you can hold a dumbbell in between your legs.



Pull-up/dip belt



Weighted pull-up with belt



Weighted pull-up with dumbbell

b) Standard overhand pull up

Working Muscle-groups: Back, Biceps, Shoulders (Rear delts), forearms

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/rLw3mIDrkNQ?t=117>

(SEE IMAGES AND INSTRUCTIONS ON NEXT PAGE)



Step 1: Adopt an overhand grip, just outside of shoulder width. Start from a full DEAD-HANG.



Step 2: Pull yourself up until at least your chin is over the bar. Imagine "pulling with your elbows" and your hands as mere "hooks".



Step 3: Lower yourself under control, returning to a dead-hang position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 4 – 6, 5 – 8, 6 – 10 or 8 – 12. Pull ups work well in a variety of rep ranges. The rep range will largely depend on how many pull-ups you are capable of.

Alternatives: Standard overhand assisted pull-ups, Standard overhand lat pull-downs, Inverted rows (**standard overhand**). If you can't perform at least 6 pull ups on your first set, consider these alternatives.

Progressions: You can gradually transition into higher rep ranges. For example, from 4 – 6, to 6 – 10 reps.

If you can perform multiple sets of 12 pull ups with your body weight, consider adding weight. You can find reasonably priced pull-up/dip belts online (e.g., amazon, ebay). Alternatively, you can hold a dumbbell in between your legs.



Pull-up/dip belt



Weighted pull-up
with belt

(SEE UNDERHAND PULL-UPS ON NEXT PAGE)

c) Underhand Pull-ups (“Chin-ups”)

Video demo: https://youtu.be/IkRUlaOi_l4

Muscles: Back (lat emphasis), biceps, forearms, shoulders (rear delts)



Step 1: Adopt an underhand grip, just outside of shoulder width. Start from a full DEAD-HANG.



Step 2: Pull yourself up until at least your chin is over the bar. Imagine “pulling with your elbows” and your hands as mere “hooks”.



Step 3: Lower yourself under control, returning to a dead-hang position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Alternatives: Neutral-grip pull-ups, Assisted neutral-grip pull-ups, D-handle lat pull-downs, V-bar lat pull-downs, Underhand lat pull-downs, Underhand Inverted rows. If you can’t perform at least 6 pull ups on your first set, consider assisted pull-ups, lat pull-downs or inverted rows.

Suggested rep range(s): 4 – 6, 5 – 8, 6 – 10 or 8 – 12. Pull ups work well in a variety of rep ranges. The rep range will largely depend on how many pull-ups you are capable of.

d) Wide-grip Pull-ups

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/mInQrSW30AY>

Working Muscle Groups: Back (Upper back emphasis), biceps, forearms, shoulders (rear delts)



Step 1: Adopt an overhand grip, around 1.5 – 2x shoulder width. Start from a full DEAD-HANG.



Step 2: Pull yourself up until at least your chin is level with, or over the bar. Note that for wide grip pull-ups, the range of motion is slightly shorter compared to other pull-up variations. Imagine “pulling with your elbows” and your hands as mere “hooks”.



Step 3: Lower yourself under control, returning to a dead-hang position. Repeat for desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 4 – 6, 5 – 8, 6 – 10 or 8 – 12. Pull ups work well in a variety of rep ranges. The rep range will largely depend on how many pull-ups you are capable of.

Alternatives: Assisted wide-grip pull-ups, wide-grip lat pull-downs, wide-grip Inverted rows. If you can't perform at least 6 pull ups on your first set, consider these alternatives.

Progressions: You can gradually transition into higher rep ranges. For example, from 4 – 6, to 6 – 10 reps.

If you can perform multiple sets of 12 pull ups with your body weight, consider adding weight. You can find reasonably priced pull-up/dip belts online (e.g., amazon, ebay). Alternatively, you can hold a dumbbell in between your legs.



Pull-up/dip belt



Weighted wide-grip pull-up with belt

e) Assisted Pull ups

Working muscle-groups: Back, biceps, forearms, shoulders (rear delts). The same form cues apply to assisted pull ups as the free bodyweight pull ups.

Video Demo (standard and overhand): <https://youtu.be/rLw3mIDrkNQ?t=195>

Video demo (Wide grip): <https://youtu.be/mInQrSW30AY?t=33>

Video demo (underhand):

<https://youtube.com/shorts/7CSHwX3b4dY?feature=share>



Assisted Neutral-grip pull-up

1

Start position: Dead-hang, shoulder-width neutral grip.

2

Pull “with the elbows” to the end position (at least chin over bar)



Assisted Standard pull-up

1

Start position: Dead-hang, just outside shoulder-width

2

Pull “with the elbows” to the end position (at least chin over bar)



Assisted Wide-grip pull-up

1

Start position: Dead-hang, 1.5-2x shoulder-width overhand grip.

2

Pull “with the elbows” to the end position (at least chin level with or over bar). Try to squeeze the shoulder blades at the top.



Assisted Underhand pull-up

1

Start position: Dead-hang, shoulder-width underhand grip.

2

Pull “with the elbows” to the end position (at least chin over bar)

Suggested rep range(s): 5 – 8, 6 - 10 or 8 – 12.

Progressions: You can gradually transition into higher rep ranges. For example, from 6 – 10 to 8 – 12 reps. You can also gradually decrease the amount of assistance that you have. Note that for the assisted pull-up machine, the lower the weight, the harder it is, since lower weight means less assistance (for the assisted pull-up machine specifically).



Assisted pull-up weight adjustment

Alternatives: Any lat pull-down, inverted row or pull-up variation

f) V-bar lat-pull downs

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/rLw3mIDrkNQ?t=161>

Working Muscle-groups: Back (lat-emphasis), biceps, forearms, shoulders (rear delts)



V-bar



Step 1: Sit down while holding the bar, and assume a position with your arms fully stretched.



Step 2: Pull with the elbows until the bar is around chest height. Control the weight up and repeat for the desired number of reps.

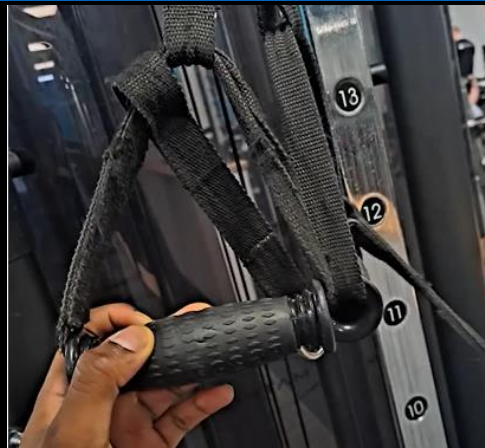
Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 – 12 or 12 -15

Alternatives: Assisted neutral-grip pull-ups, D-handle lat pull-downs, Underhand pull ups, Underhand lat pull-downs, Underhand Inverted rows (**underhand**), neutral-grip pull-ups.

g) D-handle lat pull-downs

Working Muscle-groups: Back (lat-emphasis), biceps, forearms, shoulders (rear delts)

Video Demo: <https://youtu.be/rLw3mIDrkNQ?t=169>



D-handle



Step 1: Sit down while holding the handle and assume a position with your arm fully stretched. Keep your arm close to your side.



Step 2: Pull with your elbow(s) down to your hip. Keep your arm close to your side throughout the set. Maintain an upright posture.



Step 3: Control the weight up and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Note: You can perform this with both hands simultaneously if you wish.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 or 12 -15

Alternatives: Assisted neutral-grip pull-ups, D-handle lat pull-downs, Underhand pull ups, Underhand lat pull-downs, Underhand Inverted rows, neutral-grip pull-ups.

h) Standard overhand lat-Pull downs (Straight-bar)

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/rLw3mIDrkNQ?t=174>

Working Muscle-groups: Back (lat-emphasis), biceps, forearms, shoulders (Rear delts)



Straight bar



Step 1: Sit down while holding the bar with an overhand grip (just outside shoulder-width) and assume a position with your arms fully stretched.



Step 2: Pull with the elbows until the bar is around chest height. Control the weight up, returning to the position in step 1 and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 – 12 or 12 -15

Alternatives: Standard overhand assisted pull-ups, Standard overhand pull-ups, Inverted rows (standard overhand).

i) Wide-grip overhand lat pull-downs

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/S33Jpb-BM3o>

Muscles worked: Back (upper-back emphasis), biceps, forearms, shoulders (rear delts)



Step 1: Sit down while holding the bar with an overhand grip (1.5 – 2x shoulder width) and assume a position with your arms fully stretched.



Step 2: Pull with the elbows until the bar is around chest height.



Step 3: Raise the bar until your arms are fully stretched, returning to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 – 12 or 12 -15

Alternatives: Wide-grip assisted pull-ups, Wide-grip pull-ups, Wide-grip, Inverted rows

j) Underhand Lat pull-downs

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/VLnVMIRjOS0>

Muscles worked: Back (lat-emphasis), biceps, forearms, shoulders (rear delts)



Step 1: Sit down while holding the bar with an underhand grip (shoulder-width) and assume a position with your arms fully stretched and maintain an upright posture.



Step 2: Pull with your elbows down until the bar is around chest height. Keep your arms close to your sides throughout the set. Maintain an upright posture.



Step 3: Raise the bar until your arms are fully stretched, returning to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 – 12 or 12 -15

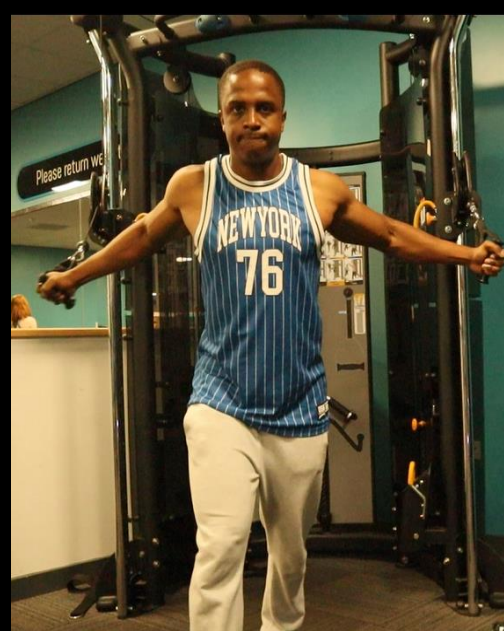
Alternatives: Underhand assisted pull-ups, Underhand pull-ups (chin-ups), Inverted rows (underhand).

8) Chest flys

a) Mid-level Cable fly (Mid-chest focussed)

Video Demo: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=445>

Working Muscle Group(s): Chest (Mid-chest Emphasis)



Step 1: Set the cable pulleys up to around shoulder height. Attach D-handles.

Squeeze your shoulder blades and start with your arms extended out to the side with a slight bend. Stand with one foot in front of the other.

Step 2: While holding the handles, move your arms inwards to the midline of the body, while keeping the shoulder blades pinched and arms at a fixed length.

Step 3: Move your arms back out to the starting position under control. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15 or 15 – 20

Alternatives: Low-to-high cable fly, high-to-low cable fly, dumbbell fly, pec dec

b) Low-to-High Cable Fly (Upper Chest Emphasis)

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=481>

Working Muscle Group(s): Chest (Upper-Chest Emphasis)



Step 1: Set the cable pulleys to the lowest height. Attach D-handles.

Squeeze your shoulder blades and start with your arms extended out to the side with a slight bend. Stand with one foot in front of the other.



Step 2: While holding the handles, move your arms up and inwards to the midline of the body, while keeping the shoulder blades pinched and arms at a fixed length.



Step 3: Move your arms back out to the starting position under control. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15 or 15 – 20

Alternatives: High-to-Low cable fly, mid-level cable fly, dumbbell fly, pec dec

c) High-to-low Cable Fly

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/5kkt2XcjejY?t=493>



Step 1: Set the cable pulleys above shoulder height. Attach D-handles.

Squeeze your shoulder blades and start with your arms extended out to the side with a slight bend. Stand with one foot in front of the other.

Step 2: While holding the handles, move your arms down and inwards to the midline of the body, while keeping the shoulder blades pinched and arms at a fixed length.

Step 3: Move your arms back out to the starting position under control. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15 or 15 – 20

Alternatives: Low-to-high cable fly, mid-level cable fly, dumbbell fly, pec dec

d) Dumbbell Fly

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/QaikJi9MnvA>

Muscles worked: Chest



Step 1: Set the bench flat. Lay down and hold the dumbbells with a neutral grip (palms facing each other) and the with arms vertically straight (with a slight bend). Keep your shoulder blades pinched.



Step 2: Lower the dumbbells to the side under control while maintaining the back positioning, until you feel a stretch in the chest. Maintain a fixed arm length.



Step 3: Raise the dumbbells back up to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps. You should feel a squeeze in your chest at the top.



***NB –** You can set the bench at an incline for upper chest emphasis.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15 or 15 – 20

Alternatives: Low-to-high cable fly, mid-level cable fly, High-to-Low cable fly, pec deck

e) Pec deck

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/7dgr1sS24Dg>

Muscle Group(s) Worked: Chest



Step 1: Set the machine up such that once you grip the handles, your back is resting against the pad, and you can grip the neutral grip handles with a stretch in your chest. Maintain a slight bend in your arms. Keep your shoulder blades pinched back.



Step 2: While maintaining positioning in the back, move the handles to the midline of the body. You should feel a strong squeeze in your chest



Step 3: Allow the weights to drift back under control to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15 or 15 – 20

Alternatives: Low-to-high cable fly, mid-level cable fly, High-to-Low cable fly, Dumbbell Fly

9) Arm Extensions

a) Lying EZ-bar Tricep Extensions (Skullcrushers)

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=141

Muscle Group(s) Worked: Triceps



Step 1: Hold the EZ-Bar just outside of shoulder width.



Step 2: Lay on the bench and position the bar so that your arms are extended, and the bar starts slightly behind the head.



Step 3: Bend your arms as far as you can. Your shoulders may roll back slightly, and you should feel a stretch in the triceps.



Step 4: Extend your arms, pushing the weight back up to the starting position. Your shoulders may roll forward slightly. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 or 12 - 15

*NB – This movement may also be performed on a straight bar if you find it comfortable. Choose whichever is the most comfortable for you.

Alternatives: Lying Dumbbell Tricep Extensions (Dumbbell Skullcrushers), Dumbbell Overhead single-arm extensions, (Leaning) overhead cable tricep extensions, Standard cable tricep pushdowns

b) Lying Dumbbell Tricep Extensions (Dumbbell Skullcrushers)

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=195

Muscle Group(s) Worked: Triceps



Step 1: Lay on a flat bench. Hold the dumbbells with a neutral, shoulder width grip with your arms extended. Hold them so that the rear ends of the dumbbells are behind your head.



Step 2: Bend your arms as far as you can. Your shoulders may roll back slightly, and you should feel a stretch in the triceps.



Step 3: Extend your arms, pushing the dumbbells back up to the starting position. Your shoulders may roll forward slightly. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Alternatives: Lying EZ-bar Tricep Extensions (Dumbbell Skullcrushers), Dumbbell Overhead single-arm extensions, (Leaning) overhead cable tricep extensions, Standard cable Tricep pushdowns

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 or 12 - 15

c) Single-arm overhead Dumbbell Extensions

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=219

Muscles worked: Triceps



Step 1: Hold the dumbbell with your palm facing in front of you, and your arms extended over your head. Keep your core tight.



Step 2: Lower the dumbbell under control behind your head by bending your arm as far as you can.



Step 3: Push the dumbbell up and out, returning to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.



NB – you can also perform this movement with a cable. Set the cable pulley to the lowest possible level and the same form cues will apply.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 – 15 or 15 - 20

Alternatives: Lying EZ-bar Tricep Extensions (Dumbbell Skullcrushers), Lying Dumbbell Tricep extensions, (Leaning) overhead cable tricep extensions, Standard cable tricep pushdowns

d) Leaning overhead cable Tricep extensions Extensions

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=242

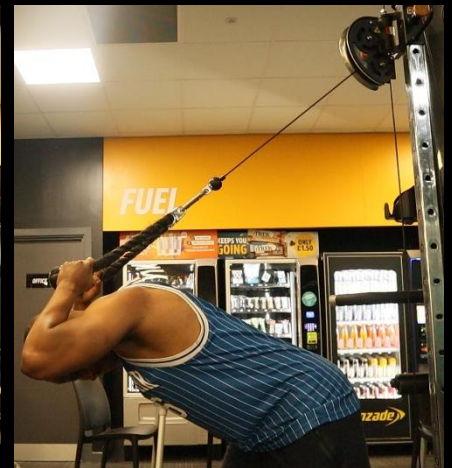
Muscles worked: Triceps



Step 1: Set the cable pulley to a level above your head. Attach a rope, walk out with it and lean forward so that you are facing the floor. Your arms should be fully bent.



Step 2: Extend your arms forward and out. (Imagine drawing an arc with your hands).



Step 3: Return the weight under control back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

NB – The rope attachment is ideal, but other attachments you can use include two d-handles, or a single straight bar.



Suggested rep range(s): 12 – 15 or 15 - 20

Alternatives: Lying EZ-bar Tricep Extensions (Dumbbell Skullcrushers), Lying Dumbbell Tricep extensions, Dumbbell (single-arm) overhead tricep extensions, Standard cable Tricep pushdowns

e) Standard cable Tricep Pushdowns

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=273

Muscles worked: Triceps



Step 1: Set the cable pulley to the highest possible level. Attach a rope, hold with your arms fully bent and adopt a slight forward lean.



Step 2: Fully extend your arms, pushing the rope down and outwards.



Step 3: Raise the weight under control and repeat for the desired number of reps.

NB – You can also use a straight bar attachment if you wish.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 – 15 or 15 - 20



Alternatives: Lying EZ-bar Tricep Extensions (Dumbbell Skullcrushers), Lying Dumbbell Tricep extensions, Dumbbell (single-arm) overhead tricep extensions, (Leaning) overhead cable tricep extensions

10) Arm Curls

a) Standard Dumbbell Curls

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=363

Muscles worked: Biceps



Step 1: Stand with your feet roughly at shoulder width. Hold the dumbbells with a neutral grip by your side, with your arms fully extended. Brace your core.



Step 2 (Front view): Curl your arm with the dumbbell while turning your hand so that it faces up. At the end of the rep, your arm should be fully squeezed. Your back should remain straight and shoulders should not move excessively.



Step 2 (side view)



Step 3: Lower the dumbbell under control, returning to the starting position with your arm fully extended. Repeat for the other arm and repeat for the desired number of reps.

***NB – Other variations**



You can perform with both hands simultaneously to save time.



You can perform with both hands simultaneously to save time.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 or 12 - 15

You can also perform the curls while seated.

Alternatives: Hammer curls, Cable curls, Incline Curls, Spider Spider Curls, Barbell/EZ-Bar Curls.

b) Hammer Curls

Video Demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=389

Working Muscle Group(s): Biceps, Forearms



Step 1: Stand with your feet roughly at shoulder width. Hold the dumbbells with a neutral grip (palms facing each other) by your side, with your arms fully extended. Brace your core.



Step 2: Curl your arm with the dumbbell, maintaining a neutral grip. At the end of the rep, your arm should be fully squeezed. Your back should remain straight and shoulders should not move excessively.



Step 2 (side view)



Step 3: Lower the dumbbell under control, returning to the starting position with your arm fully extended. Repeat for the other arm and repeat for the desired number of reps.



NB - You can perform the curls with both hands simultaneously to save time.

Alternatives: Standard Dumbbell curls, Cable curls, Incline Curls, Spider Curls, Barbell/EZ-Bar Curls.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 or 12 - 15

c) Spider Curls

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=447

Working Muscle Group(s): Biceps



Step 1: Lay prone against a bench, set at a 45-60 degree angle. Hold an EZ-bar (or straight bar, 2 dumbbells) with the arms extended.

Step 2: Curl the bar towards the chin.

Step 3: Lower the bar under control, until your arms are fully extended (not locked) and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 or 12 - 15

Alternatives: Perform spider curls with a barbell or 2 dumbbells, Standing EZ-Bar/Barbell Curls, Standing Dumbbell Curls, Cable Curls

d) Cable curls

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=410

Working Muscle(s): Biceps (and forearms, depending on the attachment)



Step 1: Set the cable pulley to the lowest possible level and attach a bar or rope to the cable. Here, a straight bar is used. If you use a rope, it will resemble a hammer curl.



Step 2: Stand with your feet around shoulder-width apart. Hold the bar with an underhand grip and your hand shoulder-width apart. Keep your elbows by your side. Brace your core.



Step 3: Curl your arm with the weight. At the end of the rep, your arm should be fully squeezed. Your back should remain straight, and your shoulders should not move excessively.



Step 4: Lower the weight under control, until your arms are near fully extended, back to their starting positions. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 or 12 - 15

Alternatives: Standing EZ-Bar/Barbell Curls, Standing Dumbbell Curls, Spider Curls, Incline curls

e) Incline Curls

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=498

Working Muscle(s): Biceps



Step 1: Set the bench at roughly a 60-degree incline. Hold a dumbbell in each hand with your palms facing forwards. Your arms should be fully extended (not locked) and be slightly behind the torso. You will feel a slight stretch in your biceps.



Step 2: Curl the dumbbells until you feel a full squeeze in your biceps. Try not to move the shoulders excessively.



Step 3: Lower the dumbbells under control until the arms are fully lengthened. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 – 15, 15 - 20

Alternatives: Standing EZ-Bar/Barbell Curls, Standard Dumbbell Curls, Hammer curls, Spider Curls, Cable Curls

f) Barbell/EZ-bar curls

Video demo: https://youtu.be/Qa_LjA4cl1g?t=296

Working Muscle(s): Biceps



Step 1: Stand up, gripping the bar with an underhand shoulder-width grip with your arms extended (but not locked).



Step 2: Curl the bar to around your upper chest, keeping your back straight and elbows close to your sides. Your shoulder might naturally move up slightly.



Step 3: Lower the bar under control, and repeat for the desired number of reps.



***NB –** You can perform these with an EZ-bar also. This may be more comfortable for the wrists. The same form cues would apply as for the straight bar.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15

Alternatives: Standard Dumbbell Curls, Hammer curls, Spider Curls, Cable Curls, incline curls

11) Side delt exercises

a) Dumbbell Lateral Raises

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/p8PG9XyOwyA?t=326>

Muscles worked: Shoulders (Side delts)



Step 1: Stand with your feet shoulder width apart. Hold the dumbbells together with a neutral grip. Have a slight bend in the arms.



Step 2: Raise the dumbbells out to the side (and slightly forward) until your arms are parallel with the ground. Imagine trying to draw the biggest semi-circle possible with the dumbbells.



Step 3: Lower the dumbbells under control and return to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15 or 15 - 20

***NB – These can also be performed seated. The rest of the same form cues apply.**



Alternative: Cable lateral raises

b) Cable Lateral Raises

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/p8PG9XyOwyA?t=382>

Muscles worked: Shoulders (Side delts)



Step 1: Set the cable pulley to the lowest possible level and attach a D-handle. Hold the handle at the mid-line of your body. You can lean to the side while holding onto a support. This may help in improving side delt engagement.



Step 2: Raise the handle out to the side (and slightly forward) until your arm is parallel with the ground.



Step 3: Lower the handle under control back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15 or 15 - 20

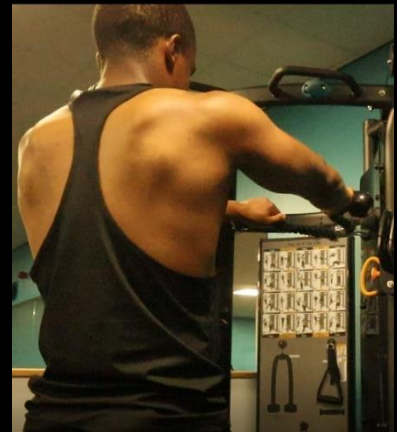
Alternative: Dumbbell lateral raises

12) Rear delt movements

a) Face pulls

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/p8PG9XyOwyA?t=448>

Muscles worked: Shoulders (Rear delts), Back (Traps, Rhomboids)



Step 1: Attach a rope to a cable. The cable pulley should be set just below the face.

Walk out while holding the rope with your arms extended in front of you, and your shoulder blades slightly forward.

The rope should be parallel with the ground and at around nose height. This is the starting position.

Step 2: Pull the rope (Think “pull with the elbows”) towards your face as far as you can, while trying to “pull the rope apart”. The end position should mimic a front double bicep pose.

Step 3: Return to the starting position, with a controlled tempo. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15 or 15 - 20

Alternatives: Reverse pec deck, skiers, reverse dumbbell flys

b) Skiers

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/p8PG9XyOwyA?t=483>

Muscles worked: Shoulders (Rear delts). Back (Lats, Traps) will be worked to a small degree.



Step 1: Lay prone against an incline bench, set at around a 45- degree angle. Hold the dumbbells out in front of you with a near-neutral grip (bottom of the dumbbells facing out very slightly), and your arms fully extended (but not locked).



Step 2: Move the dumbbells back behind you as far as you comfortably can, and out (away from your torso slightly). Your upper arms should form around a 45-degree angle with your torso.



Step 3: Lower the dumbbells under control and return to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Alternatives: Reverse pec deck, face pulls, reverse dumbbell flys

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15 or 15 - 20

c) Reverse pec deck

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/p8PG9XyOwyA?t=570>

Muscles worked: Shoulders (rear delts), Back (Traps, Rhomboids)



Step 1: Set the machine up such that once you grip the handles, your chest is resting against the pad and your shoulder blades move slightly forwards. Grip your preferred handles.



Step 2: Move your arms outwards until your arms are fully extended to your side.



Step 3: Move the weights back to the starting position in a controlled manner. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

*NB: The choice of handle is up to you. The “better” grip choice varies between individuals. Choose the grip where you feel your rear delts working the most.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 - 15, 15 - 20

Alternatives: Face pulls, skiers, reverse dumbbell flys

d) Reverse dumbbell fly

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/p8PG9XyOwyA?t=527>

Muscles worked: Shoulders (Rear delts), Back (Rhomboids, Traps)



Step 1: While standing, shift your hips back and keep your chest up. Your torso should end up being at around a 45-degree angle, with a neutral spine. Hold the dumbbells by your side with a neutral grip at around shoulder width.



Step 2: Move the dumbbells out to the side as far out to the side as you comfortably can. Imagine using the dumbbells to draw the biggest semi-circle possible.



Step 3: Lower the dumbbells under control, returning to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 -15, 15 - 20

*NB – Some variations can be found below

Example: Pronated (Overhand) Grip



The same form cues will apply as described above. Experiment and choose the grip that you feel a better sensation in your rear delts (back part of your shoulders).

Example: Seated



You can use your preferred grip when seated. Sit on a bench, lean forward, and then the rest of the form cues are the same as described in the instructions above.

Alternatives: Face pulls, skiers, reverse pec deck

13) Calf raises

a) Smith Machine Calf raises

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=756>

Muscles Worked: Calves



Step 1: Set up a platform high enough so that you get a full stretch in your calves (point toes up as far as possible) with the heels lightly touching, (or not touching) the ground. Rest the balls of your feet on the platform. Squeeze your shoulder blades and rest the bar at around shoulder height.

Step 2: Push off the balls of your feet and twist the bar backwards to remove it from the supports. Allow your heels to move down freely until you feel a full stretch in the calves. This is the starting position.

Step 3: Push off the balls of your feet as far as you can. Think about “pointing the toes downwards”. Briefly pause at the top. Keep your legs at a fixed length.



Step 4: Lower your heels under control, as far as you can. Pause briefly at the bottom. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 -15, 15 – 20, 20 - 30

Alternatives: Machine calf press, dumbbell calf raises , Leg press calf raises

b) Dumbbell Calf raises

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=764>

Muscles worked: Calves



Step 1: Set up a platform high enough so that you get a full stretch in your calves (point toes up as far as possible) with the heels lightly touching, (or not touching) the ground. Rest the balls of your feet on the platform. Hold a dumbbell in each hand.



Step 2: Push off the balls of your feet as far as you can. Think about “pointing the toes downwards”. Briefly pause at the top. Keep your legs at a fixed length.



Step 3: Lower your heels under control, as far as you can. Pause briefly at the bottom. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 -15, 15 – 20, 20 - 30

Alternatives: Machine calf press, Smith machine calf raises, Leg press calf raises

c) Machine calf press

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=762>

Muscles worked: Calves



Step 1: Set up the machine so that you get a full stretch in your calves (point your toes up as far as possible) while your legs are fully extended. Keep the leg length fixed throughout the set. Rest the balls of your feet on the platforms.



Step 2: Push off the balls of your feet as far as you can. Think about “pointing the toes downwards”. Briefly pause at the top. Keep your legs at a fixed length.



Step 3: Lower your heels under control, as far as you can. Pause briefly at the bottom. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 -15, 15 – 20, 20 - 30

Alternatives: Smith machine calf raises, Leg press calf raises, Dumbbell calf raises

d) Leg press calf raises

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=768>

Muscles worked: Calves



Step 1: Set yourself up so that you can grip the handles firmly, and the balls of your feet can make contact with the bottom of the platform while the legs are slightly bent, near full extension. Your feet should be around shoulder width. Grip firmly onto the handles.



Step 2: Push the weight up using the balls of your feet and turn the handles to remove the supports. This is the starting position.



Step 3: Lower the weight under control, as far as you can, so that your toes are facing towards you slightly. Briefly pauses in this position. Leg length should be fixed.



Step 4: Push the weight up using the balls of your feet, so that your toes point as far as possible. Briefly pause at the top. Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 -15, 15 – 20, 20 - 30

Alternatives: Smith machine calf raises, Machine calf press, Dumbbell calf raises

14) Leg curls

a) Lying Leg Curls

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/xyURvNhnFo0>

Working Muscles: Hamstrings (You may also feel your calves to a small degree)



Step 1: Set the machine up such that the rear pad is resting just above the ankles when your legs are fully extended. Secure your forearms on the front pads and firmly grip the handles.

Step 2: Curl your legs with the weight until your legs are fully bent. You may feel the pad touch your glutes. Keep your hips fixed on the pad throughout the set.

Step 3: Extend your legs with the weight under control, until your legs are fully extended (not locked). Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 -15, 15 - 20

Alternatives: Seated Leg Curls

b) Seated Leg Curls

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=731>

Working Muscles: Hamstrings (You may also feel your calves to a small degree)



Step 1: Set the machine up such that the foot pad is resting just above the ankles when your legs are fully extended. Firmly grip the handles.



Step 2: Curl your legs as far as possible with the weight. You may feel the pad touch your glutes. Keep your hips fixed on the pad throughout the set.



Step 3: Extend your legs with the weight under control, until your legs are fully extended (not locked). Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 12 -15, 15 - 20

Alternatives: Lying Leg Curls

15) Leg extensions

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/Vv4L0nscnRc?t=706>

Muscles worked: Quadriceps



Step 1: Set the machine up so that your back rests flat on the back pad, the bottom pad rests just above your ankles and your knees are as far flexed as possible.

Step 2: Fully extend your legs with the weight.



Step 3: Return to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range: 12 – 15, 15 - 20

16) Core

a) Standard Crunches

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/KAAGYBnlpew?t=84>

Main working muscle group: Abs



Step 1: Lay on the ground with your knees bent. Place your hands behind your head.

“Lean” into the ground so that you feel a slight stretch in your abs.



Step 2: Lift your shoulders off the ground. Imagine trying to bring your chest towards your belly button.

EXHALE on the way up.



Step 3: Return to the starting position.

INHALE on the way down.

Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range: 15 – 30. Crunches have a short range of motion, hence why they’re generally more suited to higher rep ranges.

Alternatives: Toe Touches, Decline sit-ups, Cable crunches

Progression: You can hold weight by your chest to add resistance, if multiple sets of 30 crunches becomes too easy for you. This can be a weight plate, a dumbbell or even a backpack.



Weighted Crunches (Start)



Weighted Crunches (Finish)

b) Toe Touches

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/KAAgYBnlpew?t=119>

Main working muscle group: Abs



Step 1: Lay on the ground with your leg risen. Raise your arms.

“Lean” into the ground so that you feel a slight stretch in your abs.



Step 2: Lift your shoulder off the ground and imagine trying to reach for your toes.

EXHALE on the way up.



Step 3: Return to the starting position.

INHALE on the way down.

Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range: 15 – 30. Toe touches have a short range of motion, hence why they’re generally more suited to higher rep ranges.

Alternatives: Standard crunches, Decline sit-ups, Cable crunches

Progression: You can hold weight to add resistance, if multiple sets of 30 toe touches becomes too easy for you. This can be a weight plate, a dumbbell or even a backpack.



Weighted Toe Touches (Start)



Weighted Touches (Finish)

c) Cable Crunches

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/KAAgYBnlpew?t=137>

Main working muscle group: Abs



Step 1: Set the cable pulley to the highest possible level.

Attach a rope if it is available (Use another attachment if the rope is not available)



Step 2: Kneel while holding the rope above your head.

Ensure your knees are flexed and hips are back. Maintain this hip/knee position throughout the set.



Step 3: Curl your torso down, thinking about bringing your "chest towards your knees."

Keep your arms fixed.

EXHALE on the way down.



Step 4: Control yourself back up, returning to the position in step 2.

INHALE on the way up.

Repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 10 – 20 (or any range in between)

Alternatives: Standard crunches, Decline sit-ups, Toe Touches

d) Decline Sit ups

Videmo demo: <https://youtu.be/lAmbPOM-yCs>

Muscles worked: Abs



Step 1: Set the bench up, with your feet firmly in the supports. Lie flat against the bench.



Step 2: Curl your torso up. Think about bringing your chest towards your knees. Exhale on the way up.



Step 3: Lower yourself under control, back to the starting position. Repeat for the desired number of reps.



NB – You can hold a weight plate, or dumbbell by your chest to make the movement more challenging.

Suggested rep range(s): 10 – 20 (or any range in between)

Alternatives: Cable Crunches, Standard crunches, Toe Touches

e) Hanging Knee raises

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/KAAGYBnlpew?t=243>

Main working muscle group(s): Abs, hip flexors



Step 1: Hang on the bar as if you are about to do a pull-up.

Keep your back tight and lower your shoulders as much as you can.

This will help keep you stable whilst performing the reps.



Step 2: Raise your knees AND hips above parallel with the ground. This flexes the spine, hence engaging the abs. You may end up leaning back slightly.



Step 3: Lower your legs under control, return to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps. Finish with your legs directly beneath you.

Suggested rep range(s): 8 – 12 or 10 – 15: As you get better at these, you can move to a higher rep range.

Progression: You can move onto hanging leg raises once these become easy (i.e., once you can perform multiple sets of 12 – 15.)

Alternatives: Reverse Crunches, Lying Leg raises, Captain's chair leg/knee raises, hanging leg raises

f) Hanging Leg raises

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/KAAgYBnlpew?t=192>

Main working muscle group(s): Abs, hip flexors



Step 1: Hang on the bar as if you are about to do a pull-up.

Keep your back tight.
Keep your back tight and lower your shoulders as much as you can.

This will help keep you stable whilst performing the reps.



Step 2: Raise your legs (straightened with a slight bend) AND your hips above parallel with the ground. This flexes the spine, hence engaging the abs. You end up leaning back slightly.



Step 3: Lower your legs under control, return to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps. Finish with your legs directly beneath you.

Suggested rep range(s): 6 – 10, 8 – 12 or 10 – 15: As you get better at these, you can move on a higher rep ranges.

Alternatives: Reverse Crunches, Lying Leg raises, Captain's chair leg/knee raises, hanging knee raises.

g) Captain's Chair leg/knee raises

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/KAAGYBnlpew?t=253>

Main working muscle group(s): Abs, hip flexors



Step 1: Suspend yourself by securing your arms in the pads. Your feet should be off the ground.



Step 2: Raise your legs/knees **AND** your hips **above parallel with the ground**. This flexes the spine, hence engaging the abs.



Step 3: Lower yourself under control, return to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range(s): 10 – 20 (or any range in between)

Alternatives: Reverse Crunches, Lying Leg raises, Hanging leg raises, Hanging Knee Raises

h) Reverse Crunches

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/KAAGYBnlpew?t=275>

Main working muscle group(s): Abs, hip flexors



Step 1: Lay down flat on the ground, with bent legs and your feet risen just above the ground.



Step 2: Move your knees towards your chest until your hips and glutes move off the ground slightly.



Step 3: Lower your legs under control, return to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Alternatives: Lying Leg Raises, Hanging leg raises, Hanging Knee Raises, Captain's chair leg/knee raises

Suggested rep range: 15 – 30.

i) Lying Leg Raises

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/KAAGYBnlpew?t=275>

Main working muscle group(s): Abs, hip flexors



Step 1: Lay down flat on the ground, with straightened legs (slight bend) risen just above the ground.



Step 2: Raise your legs until they are slightly past perpendicular to the ground. Your hips and glutes should raise off the ground slightly.



Step 3: Lower your legs under control, return to the starting position and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Alternatives: Reverse Crunches, Hanging leg raises, Hanging Knee Raises, Captain's chair leg/knee raise

Suggested rep range: 15 – 30.

j) Plank

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/KAAgYBnlpew?t=304>

Main working muscle group(s): Abs, Obliques



Step 1: Place your elbows on the ground, directly beneath your shoulders.

Step 2: Straighten your legs behind you with your toes on the floor.

Step 3: Brace your core and squeeze your glutes, keeping the spine neutral.

Step 4: Hold for the desired time frame

Suggested hold time: 30 – 60 seconds

Progression: If you can perform multiple sets of planks for 60 seconds or more, progress, apply at least one of the following progressions:



Weighted Plank: Add additional resistance on your back, using a weight plate or a backpack.



Long-lever plank: Place your elbows far in front of your shoulders.

k) Russian Oblique Twists

Video demo: <https://youtu.be/q7kUJatwFWY>

Muscles worked: Obliques, Abs



Step 1: Sit on the ground with your legs raised slightly off the ground and slightly bent.



Step 2: Twist your torso to one side as far as you can



Step 3: Twist your torso to the other side. Continue twisting from side to side and repeat for the desired number of reps.

Suggested rep range: 15 – 30 per side

Progression: If you can perform multiple sets of 30 twists per side, consider holding a weight for extra resistance.



If you want to start with an easier variation, you can have your feet on the floor.



Thank you for reading this guide. Let me know if it helped you! Make sure to take monthly progress pictures for yourself to track progress. If you wish, you can share your progress via Instagram or email (See details below). I can't wait to see transformations!



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Instagram: [@trainwithtaku](https://www.instagram.com/trainwithtaku)

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